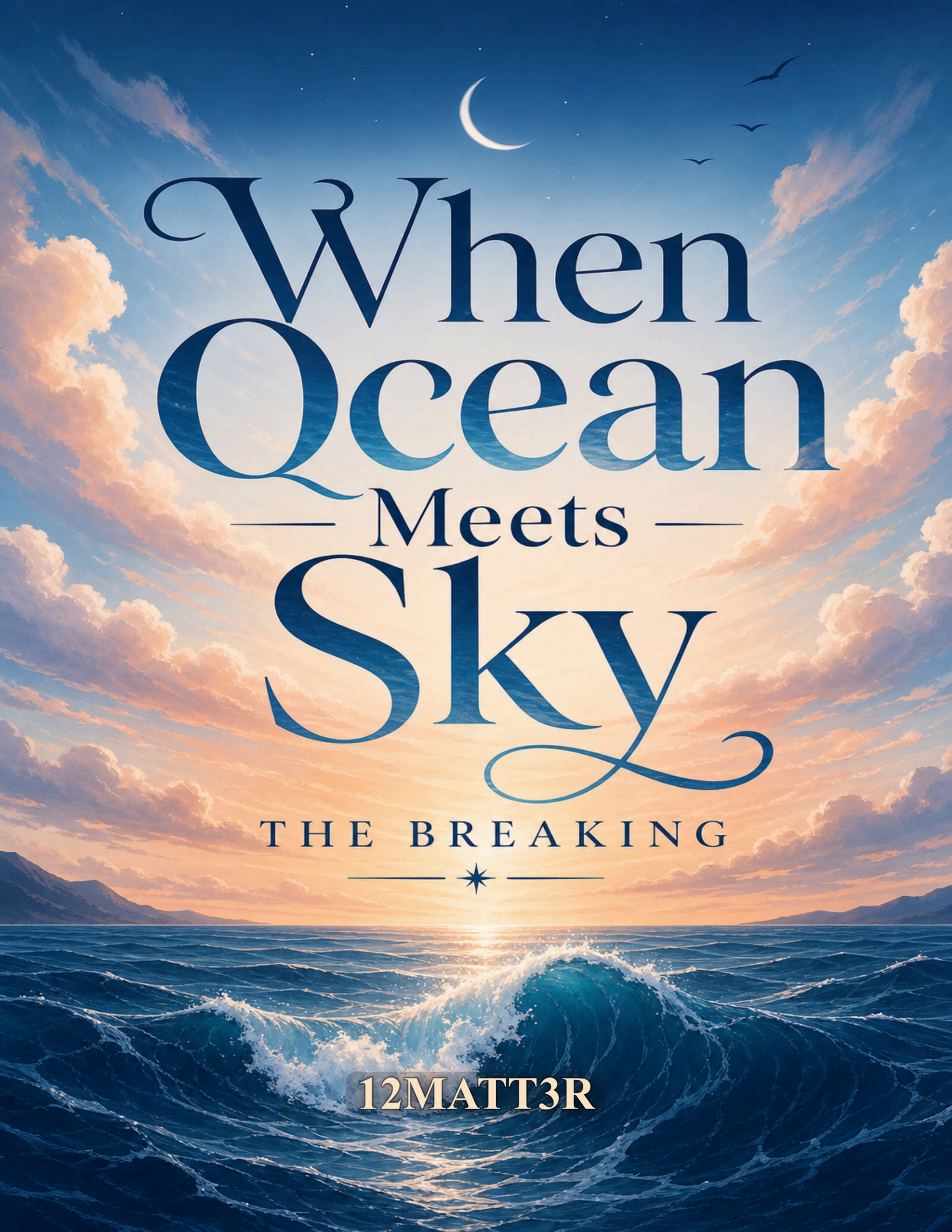




When Ocean — Meets — Sky

THE BREAKING

12MATT3R



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CHAPTER 1



The Clock That Won't Agree

The digital clock beside Kai's bed clicked from 8:00 PM to 8:00 PM again.

Its red numbers did not flicker. They simply vanished for half a second, then returned in the same rigid arrangement, as if the room had forgotten what came next.

Kai pushed himself upright.

Blue hour pressed against the window, though the sky outside should have been black by now. The blinds cast thin bars across the walls, but the bars leaned at different angles on either side of the room. His desk stood where it belonged beneath the window. The chair beside it did not. One leg touched the carpet; the other disappeared into the baseboard.

He stared at the clock.

"Eight," he said.

The speaker answered with a tiny electronic chirp.

8:00 PM.

Kai reached for his phone. The screen lit beneath his thumb.

8:00 PM.

No signal. The battery showed forty-three percent, then twenty-one, then forty-three again.

He swung his feet to the floor. The carpet felt damp through his socks, cold enough to make him flinch. He looked down. It was dry. When he pressed his palm against it, the fibers bent away from his hand in a neat circle, as though something underneath had exhaled.

“Sora?”

His voice stopped short of the door.

The bedroom was only twelve steps across. He knew that because he had counted them a hundred times while pacing during calls, arguments, and nights when sleep refused to come. The door sat six steps away now. Maybe seven. The wall around it seemed to have stretched while he watched.

He stood.

His first thought was simple: check the time somewhere else. The kitchen clock. The microwave. The street outside. Anything that could prove the numbers were wrong.

His second thought arrived colder.

Get out before the room changes again.

Kai crossed to the door.

On the third step, the blue light shifted. The walls turned a pale yellow, then a color he could not name - something between old bone and the underside of ice. The bed’s headboard slid several inches to the left without making a sound. His desk narrowed until the drawers were almost flush with one another.

Kai stopped.

The digital clock continued its quiet repetition behind him.

8:00 PM.

8:00 PM.

8:00 PM.

He pulled his phone up and opened the message thread with Sora. The last text sat at the top, sent an hour earlier.

Call me when you wake up.

He tapped the call button.

The phone rang once.

A second Kai answered.

Not a voice. A reflection in the black screen.

It showed him standing beside the bed, shoulders loose, head tilted toward the window. Kai looked down at his own body. His shoulders were raised. His hand had tightened around the phone.

The image on the screen lifted one finger to its lips.

The call ended.

Kai dropped the phone onto the bed.

“No.”

The room offered no reply. Somewhere inside the walls, pipes knocked in a slow, measured pattern. Three knocks. A pause. Three more.

He turned toward the window. The glass reflected the room, but not accurately. In the reflection, the door was open onto a dark hallway. In the real room, it was shut.

He moved closer to the glass.

The reflection-Kai remained beside the bed.

Kai raised his hand.

The reflection did not.

He stepped back so quickly his heel struck the bedframe. Pain flashed up his leg. The clock skipped.

8:00 PM.

The numbers were now green.

He grabbed the alarm clock and yanked its cord from the wall. The display stayed lit.

“Come on.”

He pulled harder. The cord stretched beneath his hand, thin and rubbery, but the plug remained buried in the socket. The socket had changed position. It was now low on the wall, near the floor, and the cord ran into it at an angle that made no physical sense.

Kai let go.

The clock’s casing was warm. Beneath the plastic, something ticked.

He backed toward the door and reached for the handle.

The knob was cold enough to burn his palm.

Before he could turn it, the bedroom light clicked on.

There was no bulb in the ceiling fixture. It had been missing for months. Still, white light flooded the room, flattening every surface. The walls snapped into a new geometry. The corners pulled farther away. The window became narrow and tall, like a slit cut into the side of a tower.

Kai twisted the handle.

It moved a fraction.

The door did not.

He braced one foot against the floor and tried again. The knob turned another fraction, then stopped with a dull internal clunk.

“Open.”

The word came out too quietly.

He turned it back and tried once more. The metal rotated under his hand, but the motion did not travel into the door. It felt detached, like turning a wheel in an empty machine.

Behind him, the clock chirped.

8:00 PM.

Kai glanced over his shoulder.

The door in the window reflection was open now.

A strip of darkness showed beyond it. Something pale stood in that darkness, too tall to be Sora and too still to be anyone.

Kai faced the real door again.

He could hear breathing on the other side.

His own breathing was sharp and uneven. The sound beyond the door matched it exactly, half a second late.

He released the handle.

The breathing stopped.

“Kai?”

Sora’s voice came from the wall beside him.

He froze.

The paint near the door shivered in a narrow ripple, as if a wave were passing beneath it. Sora spoke again, muffled by plaster.

“Kai, don’t open it.”

He pressed his ear to the wall.

The surface was cold and slightly wet. Beneath it, something scraped slowly from left to right.

“Sora?” Kai whispered.

“Not yet.”

The voice was hers. He knew the roughness at the end of her words, the way she flattened his name when she was frightened but trying not to sound frightened. He had heard it through bad phone connections, crowded rooms, and one long night when she had sat outside his apartment door without knocking.

“What do you mean, not yet?”

The ripple moved upward. A faint outline appeared in the paint: the shape of fingers pressing from the other side.

“Find the time,” Sora said. “It’s keeping the room here.”

Kai looked back at the clock.

8:00 PM.

The green digits had begun to bleed into the plastic casing. Light leaked around them in thin veins.

“What time is it?”

A pause.

Then Sora answered, "It isn't."

The fingers withdrew.

Kai stepped away from the wall. "Where are you?"

The room shifted.

The door slid farther from him, dragging the carpet beneath it without disturbing the baseboard. The walls lengthened. His bed rotated a few degrees, its legs scraping softly against the floor. The window reflection showed the room collapsing inward, every object pulled toward the door.

Kai moved before the change finished.

He lunged for the alarm clock.

The carpet buckled under his feet. His knee struck the floor, and the clock jumped from the nightstand. He caught it against his chest. The green numbers shone through his fingers.

8:00 PM.

He threw it at the window.

The clock hit the glass and fell straight down.

No crack appeared. No sound followed. It landed upright on the carpet, still glowing.

Kai stared at it.

The window had become a mirror.

His reflection stood on the other side.

Not the reflection from the phone. This one wore his gray shirt, but the collar was buttoned. Its face looked paler, its eyes dark and attentive. It raised both hands and placed them against the glass.

Kai backed toward the door.

The other Kai mouthed something.

He leaned closer despite himself.

Open.

The mirror-Kai turned his head toward the bedroom door.

Then he smiled.

Kai seized the handle again.

This time it was hot. The skin of his palm tightened against the metal, and he smelled something like scorched dust. He pulled.

The door opened inward by an inch.

Darkness filled the gap.

Not a hallway. Not the familiar strip of wall outside his room. The darkness had depth, and within it a line of blue light stretched away into the distance. Along that line stood several doors, each one identical to his.

A sound came from far inside.

"Kai."

Sora.

He leaned toward the opening.

The room behind him gave a low, settling groan. The bed shifted. The walls creaked as if the house were adjusting its weight around him.

"Kai, listen to me," Sora called. Her voice seemed to come from every door in the darkness. "Don't let it make you choose the wrong room."

His fingers tightened around the handle.

"Which one is yours?"

Silence.

Then, from the nearest door, Sora whispered, "The one that opens."

Kai pulled harder.

The door resisted.

The gap widened another inch, but the darkness beyond did not move closer. Instead, the bedroom stretched between Kai and the threshold. The carpet extended in a long, narrowing strip. The bed receded. The walls bowed inward.

He dug his heels into the floor.

The handle turned beneath his palm.

The door remained almost closed.

Behind him, the clock chirped again.

8:00 PM.

Kai looked over his shoulder.

The bedroom had lost its blue hour. Every surface now held the cold gray light from the impossible hallway. His phone lay on the bed, screen glowing. A new message appeared.

Sora: I'm behind you.

Kai did not turn.

A breath touched the back of his neck.

The hand on the door handle pulled once more, and the door answered by opening the wrong way.

CHAPTER 2

Doorway Becomes a Mirror

The door opened the wrong way, and Kai's fingers slipped from the handle.

He stumbled backward, catching himself against the wall. The breath that had touched his neck was gone, leaving only a cold patch of skin beneath his collar. In front of him, the bedroom door stood open across the room, its hinges fixed to the side that had never held them. Beyond it was not the hallway.

Beyond it was Kai.

He froze.

The doorway had become a sheet of dark, polished glass. It reflected the bedroom with merciless precision: the bent edge of the mattress, the red-numbered clock burning 8:00 PM, the phone lying faceup near the pillow. But the reflection was wrong in one small, terrible way.

Kai's reflected body stood upright.

His own shoulders were hunched from the stumble. One hand pressed the wall. The other hung loose beside his thigh. In the door, he stood with his spine straight and his chin slightly raised, as if listening to something above him.

The reflected Kai wore a colder light. It turned his skin gray and sharpened the hollows beneath his eyes.

"Kai?"

Sora's voice came from behind him.

He twisted around. The room remained empty. The bed sagged where he had left it, and the alarm clock on the nightstand glowed green beneath its casing. Its ticking had thickened into a wet, uneven pulse.

"Sora?" Kai said.

"Don't touch it again."

Her voice came from the wall beside the bed this time, muffled by plaster. Then from the ceiling. Then from the black surface of the doorway.

"Don't touch it again."

Kai looked back at the door. The reflection had not moved. Its eyes were fixed on him, though the face was angled slightly toward the upper corner of the room.

"I need to get out," he said.

"You need to find which way out is real."

The reflected Kai's mouth opened.

No sound came from it. A second later, Kai heard Sora whisper from somewhere inside the wall.

"Not that one."

Kai swallowed. The air smelled of dust and overheated metal. The red clock flickered, its digits briefly stretching into thin vertical marks before snapping back to 8:00 PM.

He stepped toward the doorway.

The reflected figure remained still.

Kai stopped with one foot lifted. His bare toes hovered above the warped floorboards. The reflection's foot was already planted.

A delay. Or an advance.

He lowered his foot.

The reflected foot came down after it.

Kai's breath caught. He raised his hand.

The reflection raised its hand first.

He dropped his arm. The other Kai followed a moment later, but not exactly. Its fingers remained spread, palm facing the glass, while Kai's hand had fallen closed at his side.

"Kai, listen to me," Sora said. The voice came from the phone now, thin and vibrating through its speaker. "The time keeps the room stable."

Kai glanced toward the bed. The phone's screen showed 8:00 PM. The battery icon read forty-three percent. He remembered it had shown a different number before. He remembered the reflection in its black screen staring back at him.

"Then tell me what to do."

A pause crackled through the phone.

"Make it show you what you can't see."

"That doesn't mean anything."

"It means stop asking the room to behave."

The door surface shivered.

Not like glass. Like water disturbed from underneath.

The reflected bedroom changed first. In it, the bed stood against the opposite wall. The clock rested on the floor, its red numbers upside down. The hallway appeared

behind the reflected Kai, narrow and pale, though there was no space behind him for one.

Kai stared at it.

"There," he whispered.

The reflected figure turned its head toward the hallway.

Kai did not.

A sharp click came from the real door. The handle rotated by itself.

He backed away. "Sora, I found it."

"No. You found what wants to be found."

The hallway in the reflection lengthened. A strip of light ran along its floor, colder than moonlight. It led away from the bedroom and vanished around a corner.

Kai's need became painfully simple. He needed to reach that path. He needed a door that opened onto it, not another version of himself.

He crossed to the bed and snatched up the phone. The screen went black beneath his thumb. For an instant, his reflected face appeared on it, smiling with lips that did not belong to him.

He nearly threw it.

"Kai," Sora said through the dark screen.

He held the phone tighter. "Where are you?"

"Close."

"That isn't an answer."

"No. It's a warning."

The alarm clock began ticking faster. Green light leaked from the seams in its casing, painting the wall in narrow bars. The red digital clock answered with a faint electronic chirp. Its display remained 8:00 PM, but the glow around the numbers pulsed in time with the alarm.

The room seemed to wait for him to choose.

Kai moved to the wall beside the doorway. He pressed his palm against the paint. It was cold and faintly damp. When he pushed, the wall gave under his hand like packed cloth.

Sora's voice rose from inside it.

"Kai, don't follow the first image."

"What am I supposed to follow?"

"The one that makes a mistake."

He looked at the doorway again.

The reflected Kai stood in the same posture as before, but the hallway behind him had changed. The light now came from the left. A thin black line marked the floor, running from the hallway to the reflection's bare foot.

Kai lifted his right hand.

The reflection lifted its left.

He stepped left.

The reflection stepped right.

The room gave a low groan. The mattress shifted behind him without anyone touching it. The phone screen lit in his hand. 8:00 PM. Forty-three percent.

Kai turned his body sideways and moved toward the door.

The reflection did the same.

He stopped.

It stopped.

He bent his knee.

It bent its knee.

He held the position until the muscles in his thigh began to burn. The reflection did not tire. Its face remained calm, almost patient.

Then Kai reached behind himself and slapped the wall.

The reflection flinched.

It happened late, but it happened.

The doorway's surface rippled outward from the reflected figure's shoulder. For one instant, the hallway behind it vanished, replaced by a close view of a white door with a brass latch. Something scratched on the other side.

Kai recognized the sound.

It was the same dry scrape he had heard before the bedroom door opened wrong.

He struck the wall again.

The reflection turned toward the sound.

Kai struck it a third time.

The reflection's head snapped around, but its body stayed facing forward. Its neck stretched too far, skin tightening above the collarbone.

Kai pulled his hand back.

The reflection followed the movement late.

There it was.

The mistake.

He stepped toward the glass, keeping his eyes on the figure's hands. His own fingers curled. The reflection's fingers curled after a delay. He raised his left foot. The other Kai copied him only after Kai had placed it down.

Each movement became a test. A shoulder. A breath. A blink.

The reflection began to lag farther behind.

Kai reached the threshold.

Cold air poured over his feet. It smelled of wet stone and something faintly sweet, like flowers left too long in a sealed room.

"Kai, stop," Sora said.

He looked at the black surface. "You told me to find the mistake."

"I told you to find what's real."

"And this is?"

"I don't know."

That frightened him more than her warnings.

The reflected hallway waited behind the other Kai. Its pale light trembled. At the far end, a shape passed across the opening - too tall, too thin, gone before Kai could decide whether he had seen it.

He put his hand against the doorway.

The surface was warm.

The reflected Kai placed its palm against the other side, but a beat too late. Its skin pressed flat against the glass. The fingers were longer than Kai's.

He jerked back.

The reflection kept its hand there.

"Kai," Sora whispered from the phone. "If it touches first, it chooses."

The glass bulged around the reflected palm.

Kai looked over his shoulder at the bedroom. The red clock still showed 8:00 PM. The alarm clock's green glow had spread across the floor, reaching toward the threshold. The phone trembled in his hand.

"What happens if I choose?"

"You already did."

The reflected Kai smiled.

Kai slammed his palm against the door.

The impact made no sound. His hand passed through the surface up to the wrist. The cold seized his arm, racing through his veins. On the other side, the reflected hand closed around his.

The grip was exact.

The timing was not.

Kai felt the fingers tighten before he had moved. Then the reflected figure pulled.

He drove his free hand into the wall and held on. Plaster tore beneath his nails. The bedroom tilted. The bed slid several inches toward the doorway, sheets dragging over the floor with a whispering scrape.

“Kai!”

Sora’s voice came from the wall, the phone, the ceiling, all at once.

He kicked backward. His heel struck the alarm clock.

The green clock fell from the nightstand and hit the floor. Its casing cracked open. The ticking stopped.

Every light in the room went out except the red numbers.

8:00 PM.

The grip around Kai’s hand vanished.

He fell forward, catching himself on the threshold. His palm landed against a hard surface. Not glass. Wood.

He looked up.

The doorway was no longer reflecting the bedroom. It showed a hallway, pale and narrow, with a white door at the far end. The brass latch gleamed beneath the colder light.

Behind him, something moved.

Kai turned.

His reflection stood in the bedroom, no longer trapped inside the door. It faced him from the threshold’s inner edge, one foot planted on the warped floorboards and the other lifted as if it had just stepped out.

Its posture was straight. Its chin was raised.

The door swung between them.

“Kai,” Sora said, very softly. “Don’t let it close.”

He seized the handle.

This time it felt solid, ridged beneath his palm, and the hinges were where they belonged. He pulled the door wide. The hallway beyond remained.

The reflected Kai moved.

Not toward him.

Toward the bed.

Kai watched it cross the room with his own uneven gait, his own slight limp, his own hand reaching for the phone. The phone's screen brightened as the reflection picked it up.

8:00 PM.

Forty-two percent.

The reflected Kai looked down at the number, then slowly turned his head toward the open doorway.

Sora's voice crackled from the phone in its hand.

"Kai, I can see you."

Kai stepped into the hallway.

The floor beneath him was cold enough to hurt. Behind him, the room remained open, but the reflection stood where he had been. It lifted one foot.

Kai lifted his own.

The reflection moved after him.

A beat late.

He stepped closer to the pale hallway and watched the delay follow. The white door at the far end waited beneath its brass latch. Somewhere behind the walls, Sora began calling his name again.

Kai took another step.

In the dark surface of the open door, his reflection lagged behind by a beat.

CHAPTER 3

Sora's Voice from the Wrong Wall

“Don't take another step.”

Kai stopped with one foot lifted.

The voice came from behind him, close enough to brush his ear, but the room gave it no body. In the black surface of the open door, his reflection remained one pace behind, its head turned toward the sound. Kai's own face stared forward.

Then the wall beside the bed rippled.

Not shook. Not buckled. The paint moved like dark water beneath glass, spreading outward from a point just above the mattress. The pale wallpaper folded into rings. The bedframe groaned, and the green-numbered alarm clock began ticking beneath its casing.

“Kai.”

This time the voice came from the wall.

He lowered his foot. The floor pressed cold through his sock.

“Sora?”

The ripple tightened. For half a second, he saw a pale hand flattened against the other side. Fingers dragged downward, leaving no mark.

“Kai, don't come through the door.”

His eyes went to the open doorway. Beyond it lay the hallway, though the hallway had no depth. It was a black panel reflecting the room, the wrong room, with the door standing where the bed should have been. His reflection still had not caught up.

"Where are you?" Kai asked.

The wall answered from his left.

"Here."

He turned.

The voice answered from behind the bed.

"Here."

The two words overlapped, one soft and one sharp. Kai's stomach clenched. He stepped around the mattress, keeping his eyes on the wall. The ripple followed him. It slid across the panel without disturbing the wallpaper, widening as though the room itself were being stretched toward him.

"Sora, say something only you would know."

Silence.

The digital clock on the dresser blinked red.

8:00 PM.

Its numbers smeared sideways, then snapped back into place. The phone beside it lit without ringing. Kai saw his own reflection on the screen, but the reflected face was looking at the wall.

"Sora," he said. "Tell me what you said before the door opened."

A breath moved through the room. It smelled of wet plaster.

"I told you the time is keeping this place stable."

Kai flinched. That was Sora's warning. He remembered the exact strain in her voice, the way she had made the words sound like something borrowed from a conversation he could no longer reach.

The ripple trembled.

"Come closer," Sora said.

"No."

The answer came from the wall, but another Sora spoke from the doorway.

"Please."

Kai looked at the mirror-door. Its reflection had changed. The reflected Kai stood beside the bed now, facing the wall. His mouth moved before Kai heard anything.

"Please," it repeated.

Kai backed away from both voices. His heel struck the bedframe. The ticking beneath the alarm clock stopped.

The sudden quiet was worse than the sound.

"Sora," he called. "If you're in there, tell me what you can see."

"Your bed."

"What else?"

"The clock."

"Which one?"

A pause.

"The green one."

Kai stared at the alarm clock. Its green numbers glowed 8:00, though the ticking had ceased. The red digital clock still showed the same time. Two clocks, two colors, one impossible hour.

"Where is the door?" he asked.

The voice from the wall said, "Behind you."

The voice from the doorway said, "In front of you."

Kai's fingers curled. He wanted to reach Sora. He wanted to drag her out before the walls folded again, before the ceiling lowered or the floor became another reflection. But the room had learned her voice, or Sora had somehow been split across it. Trusting either direction meant surrendering his back to the other.

He pulled the phone from the dresser.

The screen showed 8:00 PM. The battery percentage flickered from forty-two to nine, then to seventy-eight. His reflected face remained fixed on the glass, eyes aimed at the wall.

Kai raised the phone toward the ripple.

"Sora, if that's you, move."

The wall bulged.

A shape passed behind it, too tall and too narrow to be a person. It paused where the bed's headboard met the panel.

"Move again," Kai said.

The shape vanished.

From the wall came a muffled knock.

Once.

Then twice.

Kai counted under his breath. Sora used to knock twice when she wanted him to open a door without waking anyone. He remembered that. He remembered her hand against his bedroom door, remembered the quiet impatience in her voice.

"Kai, please."

The memory gave the sound weight.

He set the phone down and pressed his palm against the wall.

The wallpaper was warm.

Something pressed back.

Kai jerked away. A thin line appeared beneath his hand, running through the paint like a crack filled with moving water. The ripple widened and crossed the panel in a slow circle. He could hear breathing now, faint and uneven.

"Sora?"

"I'm here."

"Where?"

"Beside you."

Kai looked at the empty space near his shoulder. The air there felt colder. A strand of hair brushed his cheek.

He spun around.

Nothing.

The open door reflected him from the wrong angle. In its dark surface, something stood behind his reflected body. It had Sora's height. Its head was bent too far to one side.

Kai stumbled into the bed. The mattress dipped beside him.

The green alarm clock flashed.

8:00.

The ticking began again, faster than before.

"Sora," he said, keeping his gaze on the wall. "You're not beside me."

"I am."

"No. You're behind the wall."

"I'm behind the wall."

The answer came too quickly, as if the room had corrected itself.

Kai swallowed. "What's on the other side?"

"Nothing."

The ripple spread beneath his palm's old impression. "Then how are you speaking?"

"I don't know."

That sounded like Sora. Fear stripped the imitation from the words. Kai heard her trying not to cry, heard the effort she put into breathing quietly.

"Can you move?"

"I tried."

"What happened?"

"The room moved instead."

The wall shuddered. The bed rolled an inch toward it, dragging over the floor with a splintering scrape. Kai grabbed the headboard. Dust fell from above, but it rose halfway to the floor and hung there in a gray cloud.

"I'm coming to you," he said.

"No."

"I can't leave you in there."

"You can't tell where here is."

The warning landed harder than the others. Kai looked toward the doorway. The hallway reflection had disappeared. Beyond the door was now a narrow strip of the bedroom, repeating into darkness. Each copy contained a bed. Each bed held a green alarm clock. Each clock ticked at a different speed.

The room contracted.

The walls leaned inward by a fraction. The ceiling light stretched into a white thread, then snapped back with a pop. Kai's phone slid across the dresser and fell. Its screen struck the floor without breaking.

The reflection on it stood up.

Kai did not.

He heard Sora inhale sharply through the wall.

"Kai, don't look at the door."

"Why?"

"Because it sees you when you do."

He forced his eyes away. "What do you mean?"

"I mean it's waiting for you to choose."

The wall rippled harder. A section of it became transparent, then cloudy, then transparent again. Behind the surface, Kai glimpsed the bed from another angle. He saw himself standing beside it. He saw the alarm clock. He saw Sora's hand pressed against the wall.

Then the image shifted.

Sora was no longer behind the panel. She stood in the corner near the dresser, facing away.

Kai's breath caught.

"Sora?"

The figure turned.

Her face was hidden by darkness, but her voice came from the wall.

"Don't trust what you see."

The silhouette in the corner lifted one arm.

Kai grabbed the alarm clock. Its casing vibrated against his palm, the ticking drilling into his bones.

The figure crossed the room without moving its feet. It slid toward him, stretched thin by the warped air. The door reflection brightened around its outline.

"Kai," it said.

He threw the alarm clock.

The green-numbered clock struck the wall and burst open. Springs sprang across the floor. The ticking continued from inside the plaster.

The silhouette stopped.

For one instant, the wall went still.

Kai heard Sora whisper, "Now."

He didn't understand, but he moved. He lunged toward the ripple and drove both hands into it.

The surface gave way like cold skin.

Pain flashed through his fingers. The wallpaper clung to his hands, damp and elastic. Something seized his wrist from the other side.

"Kai!"

Sora's grip.

He pulled.

The wall pulled back.

The bed screeched behind him. The digital clock's red light flooded the room, turning every surface the color of fresh blood. Kai dug his knees into the floor and hauled with both arms.

Sora cried out.

Not from the wall.

From the doorway.

Kai froze.

The hand around his wrist tightened.

"Don't let go," Sora said from inside the wall.

The other Sora spoke from behind him.

"Kai, she's lying."

His shoulder burned. The wall's surface crawled over his forearms, sealing him to it. He could feel Sora's fingers through the thin membrane, cold and shaking.

"What do you see?" Kai shouted.

"Your face."

"What else?"

"Nothing."

The answer came from the doorway.

Kai closed his eyes.

The room filled with sounds: the broken clock ticking beneath the floor, the phone buzzing though no call appeared, the scrape of something moving behind the wall. He held on to Sora's wrist and listened past the voices.

Sora was breathing in short, frightened bursts.

The imitation was not breathing at all.

Kai opened his eyes and pulled.

The wall split from ceiling to floor.

A black seam opened beside the bed. Air rushed through it, carrying the smell of rain and dust. For a moment, Kai saw a narrow space behind the panel, impossibly deep, with fragments of the bedroom suspended inside it: the red clock, the door, the bed, his own delayed reflection.

And Sora.

She stood several feet away in the dark, one hand extended toward him. Her face was pale. Blood ran from her nose. Behind her, the space folded into a second room.

"Kai," she said. "Don't come all the way in."

"Then get out."

"I can't."

"Why?"

Her eyes shifted past him.

The silhouette in the doorway had reached the edge of the bed. It wore Sora's posture now, but its head remained angled wrong.

"Because it followed you," she said.

The seam began to close.

Kai tightened his grip. "Take my hand."

"I have it."

"No. Take the other one."

He reached into the opening.

Sora seized his fingers.

The instant their hands locked, the clocks stopped.

Every red and green number in the room went dark.

The wall slammed shut around Kai's forearms, trapping them to the elbow. Sora's face vanished behind the surface. Her hand remained in his, solid and cold.

"Kai," she whispered. "I'm here."

He could see her now, but not where she was. Her silhouette appeared in the ripple behind the wall, then in the reflection of the door, then in the black screen of the fallen phone. Three locations. One hand.

Kai pressed his free palm to the wall.

The ripple briefly cleared.

Sora's silhouette stood behind it, unmistakable, her fingers locked around his.

Then she turned her head toward something behind her.

Her mouth formed a word.

Kai could not hear it.

The wall darkened, and the shape behind Sora lifted its face.

CHAPTER 4



The Bedframe Starts Breathing

The shape behind Sora lifted its face.

Kai could not hear what it said, but he felt the words in the floorboards. They trembled beneath his bare foot, sending a fine vibration up through his ankle. Sora's silhouette remained trapped inside the wall ripple, one hand pressed against the dark surface as if she were trying to push through glass.

Kai's raised foot hovered over the carpet.

Then the bedframe moved.

Not shifted. Not creaked under some ordinary settling of wood.

It expanded.

The iron rails along the bed's side bulged outward with a slow, muscular force. The black metal curved toward Kai, joints stretching without separating, while the mattress above it rose and sank. Dust sifted from beneath the frame. A deep sound rolled through the room, too wet for wood and too hollow for breath.

Sora struck the wall.

Kai saw her mouth form his name.

"Kai!"

This time he heard her, but the voice arrived from under the bed.

He dropped his foot and stumbled backward. The bedframe contracted with a long groan, pulling its rails tight. Its legs scraped across the floor, leaving pale lines in the boards. The nearest corner had shifted several inches toward him. The gap between the bed and the wall narrowed until the mattress nearly touched the plaster.

Kai's shoulder met the corner behind him.

The same corner he had been trapped against before.

"No," he whispered.

The red numbers of the digital clock glowed across the room.

8:00 PM.

Their light stretched along the floor in thin bars, bending around the bed legs. The alarm clock answered from the nightstand with its muffled green ticking. Tick. Tick. Tick. Beneath its casing, something clicked out of rhythm.

Sora's silhouette twisted inside the wall. Her fingers dragged downward, leaving no mark.

"Don't let it close," she called.

The bedframe inhaled.

The mattress sank toward the center. Its springs complained beneath the fabric, one after another, as though the whole bed were drawing air through its seams. The rails widened again. One iron bar extended across the floor and stopped beside Kai's foot.

He jerked away.

The bar followed.

Kai lunged toward the space beside the bed, aiming for the door. The floor tilted beneath him. Not enough to send him falling, but enough to turn his stride sideways.

His palm struck the mattress. It was cold and damp, the fabric yielding under his hand like skin over a rib cage.

He pulled back.

The mattress rose against his fingers.

A pulse moved through it.

Kai shoved away from the bed and ran.

The distance to the door lengthened.

It had been three steps away. Now the dark doorway stood at the far end of a narrow corridor formed by the bed, the wall, and the warped dresser. The door's surface reflected him with that delayed, colder posture. His reflection stood still while he moved, head angled toward the bed instead of the exit.

Kai stopped.

The reflection lifted one hand.

Behind him, metal struck the floor.

He turned. The bedframe had stretched farther into the room. Its legs bent at impossible angles, planting themselves in new places. The frame was no longer a rectangle. It had become a cage with one side reaching toward him.

Sora hit the wall again.

"Look at me!"

Kai looked.

Her face was visible now, flattened beneath the ripple. Her eyes fixed on his, wide and furious. Behind her, the other shape leaned close. Its face had no features, only a pale depression where the mouth should have been.

Sora pointed down.

Not at the door.

At the floor beneath the bed.

Kai followed her gesture. The space under the mattress was black, but not empty. A thin line of red clock-light slid into it and vanished. The darkness shifted in time with the bed's breathing.

The bedframe exhaled.

The nearest rail dropped.

Kai threw himself sideways. The iron edge slammed into the floor where his knee had been. The impact shuddered through the room. A picture on the wall jumped crooked, and the alarm clock's green numbers flickered.

8:00 PM.

The rail lifted again.

Kai scrambled backward on his hands. The carpet snagged his skin. He could smell hot dust and something metallic, like rain on old pipes. The bed rose and fell above him, each movement slower than the last, but reaching farther.

He needed to get past it.

The door was no longer an exit. The reflection had warned him, or baited him. Sora was behind the wall, and the bed had become the only thing between them.

Kai shoved himself upright.

The frame expanded.

A crossbar thrust across his path at waist height. He ducked under it, but the metal grazed his back, tearing through his shirt. Pain flashed bright and immediate. He bit

down hard enough to taste blood.

"Kai!" Sora shouted.

"I'm trying!"

The words came out thin. The room swallowed the end of them.

He reached the foot of the bed. The mattress hung above him, sagging low. Its underside was stained with long gray smears, as if something had crawled across it. The floor beneath smelled of wet plaster.

Kai crouched.

The bedframe contracted, pulling the footboard inward. The opening narrowed from the width of his shoulders to the width of his chest.

He froze.

The iron rails flexed around him. The frame was not merely moving. It was adjusting. Learning the shape of him.

Sora pressed both hands against the wall. "Wait for it!"

"For what?"

Her voice broke apart. The wall stretched her words, dragging them into a low murmur.

Kai looked at the bed. The mattress rose slightly. The frame drew in.

Then the whole structure shuddered.

The alarm clock beneath its casing ticked once, twice, three times in rapid succession.

The bed stopped.

For one impossible second, everything held still: the red light on the floor, the twisted legs, the mattress bowed over him. Kai saw a narrow passage beneath the footboard, just wide enough if he turned sideways.

Sora's silhouette pointed sharply toward it.

"Now!"

Kai dropped to his knees and crawled.

The carpet was rough against his palms. A spring scraped above his head. He pushed forward, shoulder first, squeezing beneath the frame. The air under the bed was colder than the rest of the room, carrying the smell of damp earth.

Halfway through, he heard breathing beneath him.

Not the bed's deep inhale.

Something smaller.

Something close to the floor.

Kai stopped with one arm extended into the dark.

A handprint appeared in the dust beside his fingers.

Then another.

They formed one after the other, leading deeper beneath the bed.

Kai pulled his hand back.

The mattress began to lower.

"No," he said.

The bed exhaled.

Its weight descended with a long, shuddering release. The iron edge pressed against Kai's back. He shoved forward, but the passage had tightened around his ribs. His shirt caught on a jagged piece of metal.

Above him, the bedframe creaked.

Sora screamed his name from the wall.

Kai twisted hard. The fabric tore. The frame dropped another inch, grinding against his shoulder. Pain shot down his arm. He pushed with both hands, dragging his chest over the floor.

The handprints ahead of him darkened.

One finger curled.

Kai kicked backward. His heel struck the iron rail, and the bed answered with a violent contraction. The frame clamped down. His arm was trapped beneath the lowering edge.

He could feel the metal pressing into the muscle.

He thought of the door's reflection standing wrong. He thought of the digital clock refusing to move. He thought of Sora's warning about the time keeping the room stable.

The alarm clock ticked beneath its casing.

Kai reached for the sound.

His fingers found the green-numbered clock somewhere beyond the bed's edge. He could not see it. He felt its casing, warm and vibrating, then caught the cord trailing from it.

He pulled.

The clock struck the floor.

The ticking stopped.

The bedframe convulsed.

Its rail lifted just enough for Kai to wrench his arm free. He shoved forward, dragging himself beneath the footboard as the mattress slammed down behind him. Metal struck metal. The impact sent a hard vibration through his teeth.

Kai sprawled onto the other side of the bed.

For a moment he could only stare at his arm. A red scrape ran from his elbow to his wrist, bright against the dust. Blood gathered in the shallow cut and slid toward his hand.

The room had gone silent.

Not quiet. Silent.

The digital clock still read 8:00 PM, but its red glow had faded to a dull ember. The alarm clock lay on its side beneath the nightstand. Its green display was dark.

Across the room, Sora was gone.

The wall ripple remained, trembling faintly. Behind it, the shape that had stood beside her leaned toward the opening. Its blank face pressed against the surface.

Kai pushed himself up.

The bedframe moved behind him.

He turned.

The bed had settled back into its ordinary shape, four legs planted beneath it, mattress level and still. But the gap beneath the frame had vanished. There was no space now, only a solid black plane running from floor to mattress.

The narrow timing window was gone.

Kai crawled toward the wall. "Sora?"

The ripple tightened.

Her voice came through, faint and far away.

"Keep moving."

"Where?"

The wall gave a soft, wet pulse.

The shape behind it raised one hand and placed its palm against the other side.

A matching palmprint appeared in the plaster beside Kai's head.

Then the bed breathed in again.

CHAPTER 5

Catatonia on the Floor

The bed breathed in again, and Kai crawled.

Its underside scraped his back as he dragged himself beyond the frame. The mattress sagged above him, pressing down with the slow patience of something deciding whether to keep him. Dust clung to his lips. His scraped forearm burned against the floorboards.

Then the bed released him.

Kai stumbled onto the open floor and caught himself on one hand. The room had changed while he was underneath. The door stood farther away than it had a moment before, its dark surface reflecting a strip of cold light. The wall beside it shivered once, as if something behind the plaster had turned over.

He did not look at the palmprint.

Sora lay near the foot of the bed.

For half a second, relief moved through him. Then he saw the neighbor.

The man was sprawled beside her with his knees bent and his arms resting at his sides. Kai recognized him from the apartment across the hall, though he had never learned his name. One slipper was missing. His mouth hung open. His skin had the dull, waxy color of a mannequin left in a store window after closing.

Sora lay facing the ceiling.

She looked the same from a distance. Dark hair. Pale shirt. One hand curled against her stomach. But her body had settled into the floor too perfectly, as if the boards had softened around her and accepted her weight.

“Sora.”

The name came out thin.

Kai moved toward her. The floor felt cold through his jeans, colder than the air. Somewhere beneath the alarm clock, the green numbers glowed without showing the time. Its ticking had stopped.

He glanced at the door.

The hallway beyond it was black, but not empty. A faint brightness pulsed inside the dark, steady as a signal. Escape was there. Maybe. The room had offered him the door before, and the door had reflected him wrong. It had opened the wrong way. It had shown him a version of himself standing with his shoulders lowered and his hands hanging loose, as if he had already given up.

Kai looked back at Sora.

He could leave now. He could cross the room, take the handle, and refuse to look at the reflection. He could get out before the bed moved again, before the wall opened, before the room found another way to hold him.

Sora’s fingers twitched.

Kai dropped beside her.

“Sora, wake up.”

He touched her shoulder. Her skin was warm. That small fact struck him harder than the sight of her body on the floor. Warm meant alive. Warm meant there was still a person inside the shape the room had made of her.

He pressed two fingers to her throat.

A pulse beat beneath them.

“Okay,” he whispered. “Okay. I’ve got you.”

The neighbor made a dry clicking sound.

Kai froze.

The man’s head remained still, but his fingers began tapping the floor. Not randomly. Three taps. A pause. Three taps again.

Kai pulled his hand from Sora’s throat.

The tapping stopped.

He stared at the neighbor’s face. The man’s eyes were open, fixed on the ceiling. No recognition moved through them. No fear. Just a flat, gray attention aimed at something Kai could not see.

“Hey,” Kai said. “Can you hear me?”

The neighbor’s lips parted.

A breath came out, but it sounded like air escaping a punctured tire.

Kai backed away until his shoulder struck the bedframe. The metal gave a soft, wet creak beneath him.

The neighbor’s head turned.

Not toward Kai. Toward Sora.

Kai’s stomach tightened. He reached for Sora and pulled her closer, putting his body between them.

“Don’t touch her.”

The neighbor's mouth opened wider.

Nothing came out.

The room answered instead.

From the wall behind Kai came Sora's voice, low and urgent.

"Don't take another step."

Kai shut his eyes.

The same words. The same warning. But Sora was on the floor beneath his hands, and the voice was coming from the plaster.

He looked over his shoulder.

The wall had gone dark again. Not shadowed - dark, like a sheet of black water stretched beneath the paint. A shape pressed against it from the other side. Its face remained blank.

Kai's breath caught.

The shape lifted one hand.

Sora's hand lifted with it.

Kai looked down.

Sora's fingers had risen from the floor, palm open, wrist bent at an angle that made his teeth ache. Her eyes were still closed.

"No," he said.

The wall-shape lowered its hand.

Sora's hand fell.

Kai grabbed both of her wrists. "Sora, wake up."

The pulse in her neck continued. Slow. Even. Too even.

He slapped her cheek once.

The sound cracked across the room.

The neighbor's fingers began tapping again.

Three. Pause. Three.

Kai stared at Sora's face. There was no mark where he had struck her. Her skin had not reddened. The room had taken the impact and left her untouched.

He slapped her again, harder.

"Sora!"

Her eyelids fluttered.

Kai leaned close. "Come on. Come back."

Her eyes opened.

They were hers. He knew them immediately, though something in them seemed farther away than the wall. They focused on his face, then drifted past him to the bed, the door, the black ripple in the plaster.

"Sora?"

Her lips moved.

No sound emerged.

Kai bent until his ear was beside her mouth. He smelled dust and the faint metallic scent of the alarm clock's dead ticking.

"Say it again."

Sora's throat worked. Her lips formed a word.

Kai watched carefully.

Run.

That was what she shaped. Or tried to shape. The room gave him nothing. No breath, no whisper, not even the scrape of a consonant.

"Run?" he asked.

Sora's eyes widened.

She shook her head.

Kai looked toward the door. "Stay?"

Sora blinked once.

"No," he said. "Tell me. Tell me what you mean."

Her mouth opened. Her jaw trembled with effort. The muscles in her neck tightened, but the sound died before it reached the air.

The room had rules for voices now.

Kai felt the realization settle inside him, cold and exact. Sora could wake, but she could not speak. The room had left her alive and removed the part of her he needed most.

Behind him, the neighbor began to rise.

Kai heard the joints first. A series of small clicks, like someone winding a toy. He turned and saw the man pushing himself upright without using his hands. His back straightened in pieces. His bare foot slid across the floor, leaving no mark in the dust.

Sora watched him.

Her eyes filled with terror.

Kai hooked one arm beneath her shoulders and pulled. "We're leaving."

She resisted.

Not with strength. With panic. Her fingers closed around his sleeve and held on.

"I know," Kai said. "I know you're scared."

She shook her head again. Her grip tightened.

The neighbor stood.

Kai's gaze flicked to the door. The distance between them had stretched. The room seemed longer now, the floorboards running away beneath the cold light. The black hallway beyond the doorway pulsed once.

He could carry Sora. He could try.

But the bed was behind them. The neighbor was standing. The wall-shape was watching. Every second he spent trying to wake her made the door feel less real.

Kai slid his hand beneath Sora's neck.

"We go now."

Sora's eyes fixed on his.

For one terrible instant, Kai saw himself in them - not his face, but the reflection from the door. His shoulders low. His hands empty. His expression calm.

A version of him that had already decided to leave her.

He nearly did.

The thought came cleanly, without panic: Get out first. Find a way back. Bring help. If the room takes you too, neither of you leaves.

It was sensible. It was the kind of thought a person could survive by.

Sora's fingers tugged his sleeve.

Kai looked down at her.

Her mouth moved again.

This time he understood the word.

Don't.

He could not tell whether she meant don't leave or don't trust me. The room had made uncertainty another locked door.

The neighbor took one step.

His foot landed without sound.

Kai made his choice.

He seized Sora beneath the arms and dragged her across the floor. Her heels bumped over the boards. Her head rolled against his chest. She was awake, watching everything, unable to warn him.

The door did not get closer.

The bedframe shifted behind them.

Kai heard the mattress exhale.

He dragged harder.

Pain tore through his injured forearm. His vision flashed white, but he kept moving. Sora's fingers scraped at the floor, searching for purchase. When they found the edge

of a board, she clung to it.

Kai looked back.

The neighbor had not followed.

He stood beside the bed, facing the wall. His head was tilted toward the black ripple. The blank-faced shape had pressed closer from the other side. Their silhouettes overlapped until Kai could no longer tell where one ended.

Then the neighbor turned his head toward Kai.

His eyes were still fixed on the ceiling.

Kai pulled Sora another foot.

The doorway remained open, but its reflection had changed. It no longer showed Kai. It showed Sora lying on the floor, eyes closed, while something crouched beside her.

Kai stopped.

Sora's hand found his wrist.

Her eyes opened wider.

He looked at the reflection again.

The crouching thing beside her had his shape.

Its face was turned toward the door.

Kai's wrist tightened beneath Sora's fingers. Her nails dug into him, anchoring him to the floor.

The alarm clock began ticking.

Once.

Twice.

The green glow flickered, and for an instant the casing showed a time.

8:00 PM.

Kai stared at it.

The red-numbered digital clock across the room answered with a weak flash from beneath the bed. His phone vibrated in his pocket. He did not take it out. He already knew what it would show.

Sora pulled his wrist again.

Kai crouched and gathered her against him. "I'm sorry."

She shook her head violently.

"I can't understand you."

Her lips formed another word. No sound came.

He pressed his forehead to hers. Her skin was cold now, though her pulse still beat beneath his thumb.

"I'm not leaving you."

The room went silent.

Even the clock stopped.

For a moment, nothing moved. The neighbor stood motionless. The wall-shape flattened into the plaster. The doorway lost its depth and became only a black rectangle.

Kai held Sora tighter.

Then her eyes opened fully.

Not the slow, frightened opening from before. A sudden, complete awakening.

She stared directly at him.

Her mouth parted.

No voice came, but her expression changed. The terror remained, buried beneath something clearer. Recognition. Anger. A warning she could not force through the room's sealed air.

Kai shook her shoulders.

"Sora. Look at me."

Her gaze stayed on his.

"Are you alive?"

She blinked once.

"Can you hear me?"

Another blink.

"Can you move?"

Her fingers curled against his shirt.

Kai nodded, though he did not know whether she could read the gesture. "Good. Good, that's enough."

Behind Sora, the neighbor lowered himself back onto the floor.

Not falling. Not collapsing.

Settling.

His body arranged itself beside hers, arms at his sides, face turned toward the ceiling. Like a mannequin returned to its display.

Sora's eyes shifted toward him.

Kai followed her gaze.

The neighbor's mouth was closed now.

The black ripple in the wall had vanished.

The room looked almost ordinary except for the bodies on the floor, the open doorway, and the two clocks showing the same impossible hour.

Kai turned back to Sora.

She was awake.

She could not speak.

And when the alarm clock began ticking beneath its casing again, her eyes moved toward the sound before he heard it.

CHAPTER 6

Sora Points at the Window

Sora's eyes shifted toward the window, and her hand rose from the floor.

The movement was small but deliberate. Her fingers trembled once, then pointed past Kai, toward the glass where the bedroom's warped light gathered in a pale square. The alarm clock ticked beneath its green casing. Kai heard it now, each click arriving a fraction too late, as if the sound had to cross the room twice.

He crouched beside her. "The window?"

Sora could not answer. Her mouth opened, but no voice came. Her gaze stayed fixed beyond him.

Kai glanced at the wall behind her. The plaster still carried the matching palmprint beside his head. Its fingers had lengthened since he last looked, stretching toward Sora's shoulder in thin gray grooves. He moved between it and her.

"Are you telling me to go there?"

Sora pointed again.

The window stood across the room, farther away than it had been before. Not physically. The bed, the dresser, and the dark slice of the open door remained where they belonged, but the distance between them had deepened. The floorboards ran toward the window in narrowing strips, each one angled slightly differently. The red-numbered digital clock on the dresser displayed 8:00 PM. His phone lay beside it, its screen also fixed at 8:00 PM, though the battery percentage had changed from forty-seven to twelve without the phone moving.

The room was waiting for him to choose a direction.

Kai slid one arm beneath Sora's shoulders. "We're going to the window."

Her body resisted. Not from weakness. Every muscle in her seemed locked against the floor, as if the room had fastened her there. Kai pulled harder. Her sleeve scraped over the boards, and a sharp breath escaped her.

The sound came from the wall.

Kai froze.

"Sora?"

The wall beside the bed gave a soft ripple. Her voice traveled through it, muffled and stretched thin.

"Don't..."

Sora's eyes widened. She shook her head violently.

The wall spoke again, wearing her voice.

"...move."

Kai looked from the darkened plaster to Sora's pointing hand. "That isn't you."

Her fingers curled against the floor. She pointed toward the window a third time, then dragged her index finger through the dust. A crooked line appeared between them and the glass.

Not the door.

The window.

Kai understood enough. He hooked his hands beneath her arms and hauled her upright. Her feet folded beneath her, useless. He pulled her against his chest,

dragging her backward.

The room changed.

The bedframe exhaled behind them.

Its wooden slats creaked, and the mattress lifted as though something beneath it had rolled over. Kai felt the vibration through the floor. The alarm clock's ticking stopped.

Then every object in the room leaned toward the bed.

The dresser legs scraped. The phone slid across its surface, screen glowing with Kai's reflection. In the reflection, he stood upright and uninjured, watching Sora lie facedown on the floor. His reflected head turned toward the window.

Kai tightened his grip on Sora.

"Keep looking at me," he said.

She did not. Her eyes stayed on the glass.

The first step took him nearly to his knees. The floor bowed under his weight, boards dipping like wet paper. Sora's fingers caught at his wrist. Her nails pressed into the cuts along his palm from the bedframe.

"Don't let go," Kai whispered.

At the edge of the room, the window flickered.

For one instant it showed the outside: a black sky, no street, no neighboring buildings. Then it showed the bedroom from the other side, with Kai and Sora standing inside it. Then the glass became a dark mirror.

Something pale moved across that reflection.

Kai stopped.

A moth hovered before the window.

It was larger than any moth should have been, its wings gray and translucent, patterned with tiny dark bars. It circled the same point in the air, never rising or falling. Each turn was exact. Each pause lasted the same length.

Sora tapped his wrist.

Once.

The moth completed a circle.

Twice.

Another circle.

Kai watched it. The alarm clock remained silent, but he could feel a pulse in the floor, matching the moth's rotations.

"What are you counting?" he asked.

Sora's lips formed a word without sound.

Kai leaned closer. "Time?"

She shook her head.

The moth turned. Its wings made no noise, yet the room answered with a faint click.

Kai looked at the digital clock. 8:00 PM.

His phone screen went black. In its reflection, the other Kai had moved closer to the window.

Kai pulled Sora another foot. The distance collapsed beneath him, then stretched. His knee struck the floor. Pain flashed up his leg. Sora slipped from his arms and landed hard on her side.

Her hand struck the boards.

The room lurched.

The open door slammed shut.

Kai spun toward it. The dark surface reflected him standing with one hand on the handle. The reflected Kai wore a posture he did not recognize - shoulders lowered, head tilted, fingers already curling around the knob.

Sora hit his ankle.

He looked down. She was pointing at the window, her face pinched with panic.

The wall rippled again.

"Kai," it whispered in her voice. "Come back."

He backed away from the door.

The reflected Kai smiled.

Kai grabbed Sora beneath the arms and dragged her forward. The floorboards buckled behind them. Something struck the underside of the room with a heavy, deliberate knock.

The moth circled.

Click.

Sora's hand tightened around his sleeve.

Click.

Kai reached the center of the room. The walls had begun to bow inward, narrowing the space around them. The dresser stretched taller, its drawers opening one by one. Inside each drawer lay the same black strip of hallway he had seen beyond the door.

He kept moving.

"Almost there," he said.

Sora stared at him.

He realized she was not looking at his face. She was looking over his shoulder.

The bedframe had moved.

It stood between them and the wall, but its legs no longer touched the floor. The entire frame hovered a few inches above the boards, mattress sagging toward the center. Beneath it, the darkness breathed.

Kai pulled Sora sideways.

The bedframe dropped.

Wood struck the floor where her head had been. The impact threw dust into the air. Kai stumbled, dragging Sora with him, and struck the wall beside the window.

Cold glass pressed against his shoulder.

The moth stopped circling.

It hung in front of the pane, wings open.

Sora reached for it.

Kai caught her hand. "No."

She looked at him, furious and terrified. Her mouth worked soundlessly. Then she pointed at the moth, pointed at the glass, and pressed two fingers against her own chest.

Her reflection appeared in the window.

It did not match her.

The reflected Sora stood alone in the room, her face turned toward the open door. Behind her, the blank-faced shape rose from the wall.

Kai shoved Sora away from the glass.

The window flashed white.

For a moment, the room vanished. There was only the pane, the moth, and the reflection of Kai's hand pressed against it. The glass felt warm beneath his palm.

A line appeared in the window.

Not a crack. A seam.

It ran vertically from the top of the frame to the sill, so fine Kai could barely see it. Beyond the seam lay a strip of darkness that did not belong to the night outside. It looked like the hallway, but narrower, folded flat.

Sora struck his arm.

He turned. She pointed at the seam.

"The safe area," Kai said.

She nodded.

The moth began to circle again.

Kai put both hands against the window. The glass flexed under his weight. Behind him, the bedframe scraped forward. The wall whispered Sora's name. The digital clock emitted a single red blink.

8:00 PM.

Kai pushed.

The seam widened by the thickness of a fingernail.

A cold draft touched his face. It carried no smell, only the sensation of distance, as though the air had traveled through a place too large to cross.

Sora crawled beside him. Her fingers found the seam and pulled.

The window opened inward.

Not the frame. Not the glass.

The darkness between them folded back like a door.

Kai saw a narrow passage beyond it, lit by a weak blue glow. The floor there was level. The walls did not breathe. At the far end stood another window, showing the same moth.

A way through.

He reached for Sora.

The bedframe struck the wall.

The impact knocked her hand from the opening. The dark passage shuddered, and the blue light went out.

"No," Kai said.

He seized Sora around the waist and shoved her toward the gap. Her shoulder crossed the threshold. Her body jerked as if something on the other side had caught her.

Her eyes locked onto his.

Kai pulled.

The darkness resisted.

Behind them, the alarm clock began ticking again, faster now. The sound filled the room until it became a frantic metallic chatter. The wall beside Kai bulged outward. A pale hand pressed through the plaster, fingers searching.

Sora's silent scream twisted her face.

Kai wrapped one arm around her and drove his other hand into the seam. The opening widened. The cold beyond it burned his fingers.

"Hold on."

He pulled with everything left in him.

Sora slid free.

So did the room.

The floor tipped. The bedframe lurched toward them. Kai lost his grip, and Sora fell through the opening alone. Her hand remained visible for one second, reaching back.

Kai grabbed it.

The moth completed another circle.

Click.

The window snapped shut.

Sora vanished.

Kai's fingers closed on empty air.

He struck the glass with his palm. Pain burst through his injured hand. On the other side, the moth hovered inches from the pane, its wings spread wide. It had stopped moving.

The room behind Kai settled into silence.

The door stood open again.

The bedframe rested against the wall.

The clocks both displayed 8:00 PM.

Kai pressed his forehead to the window. In the black glass, his reflection stared back. Sora was not beside him. Behind his reflected shoulder, however, a pale hand lifted and pointed toward the far end of the dark passage.

Then the moth tapped the glass.

Once.

And somewhere beyond the window, Sora tapped back.

CHAPTER 7

The Moth Writes a Path

Kai turned from the window before Sora could tap again.

The moth hung against the glass, its wings beating without sound. Beyond it, the room's reflection showed only a pale smear where Sora's face should have been. Kai reached for the window latch, but the moth peeled away first and drifted down.

Not toward the floor.

Across it.

Kai followed.

The moth moved in short, deliberate bursts, hovering inches above the boards. Wherever its wings passed, a faint silver line appeared beneath it, thin as a scratch in ice. The line vanished when the moth moved on, but not completely. Kai could still see it if he looked from the corner of his eye.

"Sora?" he called.

The glass gave a soft knock.

He looked back. Sora's hand was pressed to the other side of the window now. Her fingers were flattened against the pane, the nails dark beneath the warped light. Her mouth formed his name, but no sound crossed the glass.

Kai put his palm against hers.

The window was cold enough to burn.

The moth dropped suddenly.

Kai snatched his hand away and stepped after it. His injured arm struck the wall. Pain flashed from his wrist to his elbow, and the room answered with a low wooden groan. Behind him, the bedframe shifted a fraction across the floor.

He kept moving.

The moth crossed the boards toward the foot of the bed, then veered sharply left. It paused above a knot in the wood. The knot opened like a black pupil.

Kai stopped.

The green-numbered alarm clock ticked beneath its casing somewhere behind him. The red-numbered digital clock still displayed 8:00 PM, its light staining the room the color of fresh blood. His phone lay near the wall, screen glowing with the same time and a battery percentage that had changed again.

He did not look at it.

The moth rose, traced a crooked angle around the bed, and continued toward the center of the room.

"Kai."

Sora's voice came from the wall.

He spun toward the sound. The plaster beside the window rippled once, the way water trembled after something passed beneath it. Sora appeared inside the ripple from the shoulders up. Her eyes were wide.

"Don't follow it," she said.

Kai stared at her. "You're the one who tapped."

"I was trying to tell you not to."

"You're outside the window."

"No." Her face tightened. "I'm here."

The moth flickered between them, its wings throwing pale dust into the air.

Kai looked from Sora to the line forming beneath the insect. "Where is here?"

Sora's mouth opened. For a moment, nothing came out. Then the wall behind her flexed, and her image stretched sideways until one eye dragged behind the other.

"Find where it ends," she whispered. "Not where it starts."

The ripple snapped shut.

Kai stood alone with the moth.

It moved again.

He followed the line around the bedframe. The mattress shuddered as he passed. A shallow depression appeared in the blankets, as if something invisible had sat down and watched him go. The smell of damp iron filled his nose.

At the first corner, the moth stopped.

A second silver line branched away from the first, running beneath the bed.

Kai crouched. The space beneath it was black, though the room's red light reached every other gap. He could still feel the scrape along his ribs from crawling under there. The skin had stiffened beneath his shirt, sticky with dried blood.

The moth dipped into the darkness.

"No," Kai said.

It vanished.

The line beneath the bed remained, trembling faintly.

The alarm clock ticked faster.

Kai lowered himself to one knee. The floor felt warm beneath his palm. Not warm like wood warmed by a lamp. Warm like skin.

He pulled his hand back.

The silver line shifted.

It slid away from his fingers, retreating beneath the bed as if it had noticed him.

Kai rose too quickly and struck his shoulder against the bedframe. The frame gave a small, wet creak. Its nearest leg bent toward him.

He stumbled backward.

The bed moved.

Not far. Just enough to close the space between its legs and the wall.

The route beneath it was gone.

The moth reappeared on the other side, hovering beside the digital clock. Its wings beat in silence. It traced another line, this one curving toward the door.

Kai stared at the path. It did not look like a warning. It looked like a sentence written in a language that kept erasing itself.

The door's dark surface reflected him.

His reflection stood with its head tilted, watching the moth. Kai's hands hung at his sides.

His own hands were clenched.

The reflected Kai lifted one finger and pointed toward the far corner.

Kai did not move.

The moth flew there.

The corner waited between the wardrobe and the wall, too narrow for a person. The moth hovered over the boards, and a pale thread appeared beneath it. The thread ran straight to the center of the room, crossing every other line.

A route.

Or a trap.

The reflected Kai smiled.

Kai grabbed the alarm clock's cord.

The ticking stopped.

Every line on the floor disappeared.

The moth dropped from the air and struck the boards with a dry, papery sound.

For one second, nothing moved.

Then Sora screamed from inside the wall.

Kai released the cord. The alarm clock began ticking again beneath its casing, but the sound had changed. Each tick came from a different place in the room.

The moth lifted itself.

The line returned, brighter now. It ran from the corner to Kai's feet.

Sora's voice followed the ticking. "It needs you."

Kai looked at the wall. "What does?"

"The room."

The corner bent inward.

Not the wall itself. The distance between the wardrobe and the plaster folded, narrowing until the two surfaces nearly touched. Something pale pressed through the seam. A fingertip, perhaps. It dragged downward, leaving no mark.

Kai's reflection turned toward him.

Its mouth moved.

Step there.

The words did not reach him as sound. They appeared in the reflection's throat, black against the cold light.

Kai backed away from the line.

The floor beneath his heel softened.

He jerked forward. A dark ripple spread through the boards from the point of contact, widening in slow circles. The moth rose and flew along the silver path, stopping at the center of the room.

There, the line ended.

Kai had expected a crack, a door, some visible wound in the bedroom. There was nothing. Only floorboards, dull and ordinary beneath the red glow.

The moth touched down.

Its legs sank through the wood.

Kai's breath caught.

The boards flexed around it, not breaking, but receiving it. A faint seam appeared beneath the moth, curving like the outline of a threshold.

Sora came through the wall again, lower this time. Her hands emerged first, gripping the plaster's edge as if it were fabric.

"Kai," she said. "Don't let it choose your weight."

"What does that mean?"

"It doesn't know the difference between opening and falling."

The moth spread its wings.

The seam widened by a hair.

Behind Sora, something moved in the wall. The blank-faced shape leaned close enough that its shoulder pressed through beside her. No features showed where its face should have been, only a smooth pale surface catching the red light.

Sora looked at it and went rigid.

"Kai," she whispered. "Now."

He understood the question at last. The lines were not telling him what the room wanted. They were showing him where it could no longer pretend to be whole.

He stepped toward the center.

The bedframe groaned behind him. Its legs scraped across the floor, chasing.

Kai kept his eyes on the moth.

The first line vanished beneath his left foot. The second trembled under his right. The floor buckled, then settled.

Nothing opened.

He shifted his weight forward.

The room screamed.

The sound came through the walls, the clocks, the glass, and the bones of his injured arm. The red numbers on the digital clock stretched into vertical strokes. The window

flashed white. Sora disappeared from the wall.

Kai nearly fell.

The moth struck his ankle.

Its wings were cold and powdery against his skin. He flinched, and the silver line beneath him leaped toward the door.

“No,” he said.

The line pulled.

His foot slid across the floor without lifting. The boards rippled under his sole, each wave rising and collapsing. The door reflection followed the motion a beat late, then stopped altogether.

Kai seized the edge of the wardrobe.

The wood was slick. Something inside it knocked once.

The moth crawled from his ankle to the floor. It waited on the traced line.

The alarm clock ticked.

Sora’s voice came from behind the door. “Kai, open it.”

He looked at the handle.

The dark surface reflected him again. This time, his double stood with one foot already on the silver seam. Its face was turned toward the doorway, but its eyes stared directly at Kai.

“Which Sora?” Kai asked.

The reflection’s lips parted.

The room answered with Sora’s voice from three places at once.

"Please."

The bedframe scraped closer.

Kai let go of the wardrobe.

He placed his foot on the line.

The floor rippled upward like a doorway forming.

CHAPTER 8

Shadows Stretch Past Their Owners

“Don’t move,” Sora said.

Kai’s foot was planted on the moth-marked line, and beneath it the floor began to rise.

Not bend. Rise.

The boards lifted in a slow, wet swell, carrying the pale line upward between them. Dust slid toward the seam and vanished into its trembling edge. Somewhere behind Kai, the green alarm clock ticked beneath its casing, each click muffled as though wrapped in cloth. The red numbers of the digital clock remained fixed at 8:00 PM.

Sora stood near the window, one hand braced against the wall. The moth was gone from the glass. Only a dark smear remained where it had tapped.

“Kai,” she said. “Look down.”

He did.

His shadow lay beneath him, but it no longer matched his shape.

The room’s light came from nowhere Kai could find, a cold gray spilling across the floor. His body stretched thin beneath it. His head, shoulders, and raised arm were all there, but the shadow’s arm reached farther, its fingers spread toward the rippling seam.

Kai’s mouth went dry. “That isn’t mine.”

"It is," Sora said. "That's the problem."

The floor rose another inch. The line beneath Kai's shoe shivered. A pressure tugged at his ankle, not from the seam but from the dark shape attached to him. His shadow's fingers dragged across the boards, leaving no mark, yet the sound was unmistakable: nails scraping wood.

Kai shifted his weight toward Sora.

The shadow did not.

Its head remained beneath him while its body leaned toward the seam. The separation pulled at his skin. A sharp ache climbed from his heel into his calf, as if a thread had been sewn through bone and someone had begun drawing it out.

"I need to reach you," Kai said.

"You need to stay on the line."

"The line is moving."

"So are we."

The wall behind Sora rippled. For a moment, Kai saw the bedroom reflected in it: the bed crouched low, the clocks hanging at impossible angles, the door open onto a hallway filled with colder light. Then the image folded inward, and Sora's outline doubled.

One Sora remained by the window.

Another stood inside the wall.

Kai blinked, and the second one was gone.

Sora's face tightened. "Don't look at the wall."

"I saw - "

"I know what you saw."

The floor continued to lift, making the space between the bed and the seam narrower. The bedframe pressed against the boards with a groan. Its legs bent slightly, as though the thing were adjusting itself to watch him. Kai remembered crawling beneath it, the scrape across his ribs, the alarm cord snapping taut in his hand. He could still feel the raw skin beneath his shirt.

The seam widened.

It was no longer a line. It had become a narrow vertical fold in the floor, black at its center and silver along the edges. Ripples traveled outward from it, passing under Kai's boots. Each one changed the angle of the room. The window leaned left, then right. Sora's body seemed to slide a fraction away from itself.

Kai lifted his other foot.

His shadow jerked.

Pain flashed through him. His knee buckled, and he caught himself before falling. The shadow's hand stretched farther, its fingertips slipping over the raised floor toward the fold.

"Kai!" Sora pushed away from the wall. "Don't fight it like that."

"Then tell me what to do."

"Keep it attached."

"I'm trying."

"No. You're trying to walk."

The accusation struck harder than it should have. Kai looked at her. Her eyes were fixed on his feet, not his face.

"Then help me," he said.

Sora stepped onto the shifting boards.

The room gave a low, hollow shudder. The bedframe's nearest leg scraped across the floor and blocked her path. Sora stopped inches from it.

"Move," she whispered.

The bed did not.

Its frame rose and fell once.

The mattress above it sagged toward Sora, though nothing lay on top. A smell drifted from beneath the bed: damp wood, dust, and the sour odor of something kept too long in a sealed room. Sora backed away.

Kai felt the pull intensify. His shadow had reached the seam. Its fingers curled over the silver edge.

"Sora," he said.

"I can't get around it."

"Go under."

Her gaze snapped to him. "You know what's under there."

The alarm clock ticked again. Then again, louder.

The bedframe inhaled.

Its wooden slats drew inward with a long creak, narrowing the gap beneath it. Sora's face went pale.

"Kai, the room is closing."

He tried to pull his foot back from the line.

The shadow's heel stayed fixed.

For one terrible second, Kai felt two directions claiming him. His body leaned toward Sora while his darkness stretched toward the seam. His ankle burned. The skin around his heel prickled, then went numb.

The seam whispered.

It sounded like Sora calling from inside the wall.

"Kai."

Sora heard it too. Her head turned.

"Don't," Kai said.

The voice came again, softer. "Kai, come here."

Sora looked at him. "That wasn't me."

"I know."

But the voice used her exact tone, the small break at the end of his name, the breath she always took before saying something difficult. It came from the fold in the floor now, rising through the black gap.

Sora reached for him.

The bedframe shifted between them.

A wooden corner slammed down where her hand had been. She recoiled, and the wall behind her rippled hard enough to make the window glass tremble. The room flashed white.

Kai saw the blank-faced shape behind the wall.

It stood directly behind Sora, pressed against the other side of reality. Its head tilted toward his shadow. Where its face should have been, there was only smooth, pale skin.

Sora did not see it.

"Kai," she said. "Your shadow is almost across."

He looked down.

The shadow's torso had thinned. Its edges frayed into strands that crossed the floor independently, all of them winding toward the seam. Its head remained beneath him, but its face had turned upward.

Kai saw his own features there.

Not as a reflection. As a separate expression.

The shadow was smiling.

He made a decision before fear could stop him.

Kai lunged.

His planted foot tore free of the moth-marked line. The pain was immediate and brutal, a hot rip through his ankle. His shadow snapped taut between him and the seam. The floor surged upward, pitching him forward.

Sora caught his wrist.

The impact drove him to one knee. The boards were cold beneath his palm, slick with a fine film of moisture that had not been there moments before. The seam opened wider beside him. Blackness breathed from it.

"Hold on!" Sora shouted.

Kai gripped her hand with his free one. Her fingers were freezing.

The shadow pulled.

His shoulder wrenched toward the fold. His body stretched between Sora and the darkness, and for an instant his arm looked too long, the bones beneath the skin drawn out like wire. Sora's grip slipped down to his wrist.

"Kai, let go of the floor!"

He looked at his hand.

The boards beneath his palm had softened. They clung to his skin, grain curling around his fingers. He yanked upward. Splinters pierced his palm, and the floor released him with a wet pop.

The bedframe groaned behind Sora.

She glanced back.

The mattress had lifted several inches, revealing the black space beneath. Something moved in it, slow and deliberate. Not the shape from the wall. Something lower. Something that had learned the sound of breathing.

"Don't look," Kai said.

"I'm not looking at it."

"You are."

"I'm looking for a way out."

"There isn't one."

The seam snapped open.

A strip of the floor folded downward, exposing a depth that could not fit beneath the bedroom. Kai saw the narrow passage beyond the window, then the hallway from the door, then the underside of the bedframe, all occupying the same impossible space. In each place, another version of his shadow moved.

Sora's wrist twisted in his grasp.

"Kai!"

His shadow had detached at the waist.

The upper half still clung to his feet, but the lower half lay across the rippling floor, reaching for the fold. Its fingers closed around nothing. The darkness between them widened.

Kai pulled Sora toward him.

She stumbled over the raised boards and struck his chest. He caught her by the shoulder. For a moment they were pressed together, her hair against his cheek, the cold smell of dust in both their breaths.

The shadow pulled again.

Kai's knees slid toward the seam. Sora dug her heels into the floor.

"Move," he said.

"I am moving."

"Not enough."

The bedframe shifted behind her, cutting off the space she had occupied. Its leg dropped with a crack. The floor between the bed and the seam narrowed to a trembling strip.

Sora looked down at their locked hands. "If it separates, what happens?"

Kai could not answer.

The shadow answered for him.

It lifted its head.

His own face looked back from the floor, mouth opening without sound. Then it turned toward Sora, as though recognizing her.

Sora's grip tightened. "It knows me."

The blank-faced shape behind the wall pressed closer. The wall bulged around its shoulders.

Kai pulled hard.

The pain in his ankle became white noise. He dragged Sora across the rising floor, one step, then another. Each movement left part of his shadow behind. It stretched thinner, longer, its edges trembling like wet cloth caught in wind.

The seam was three feet away.

Then two.

Sora stumbled. Kai caught her wrist and hauled her forward. The floor buckled beneath them. The silver edge of the fold flashed, and the temperature plunged. Frost formed along the boards around Kai's hand.

"Kai, stop!"

He did not.

If he stopped, the shadow would reach the seam first. If it crossed without him, he knew with a certainty that had no source but his bones, something would remain behind.

The shadow's fingers touched the black gap.

Kai felt the contact in his teeth.

He seized Sora's wrist with both hands and yanked her toward the seam.

She cried out as her feet left the floor.

The rippling fold opened beneath them, swallowing the moth-marked line, the warped boards, and the cold light. Kai's shadow tore wider behind his heels, its body stretched between them and the darkness.

Sora's wrist slid against his palms.

"Kai!"

He dragged her forward before the separation completed.

Behind him, his shadow let go of his feet.

And the thing wearing his face stepped into the seam.

CHAPTER 9

Neighbor's Name Gets Replaced

Kai had one hand locked around Sora's wrist when his shadow stepped away from his feet.

The thing wearing his face stood in the seam behind them, one shoulder turned as if it had just entered a room where it belonged. Kai did not look back again. He dragged Sora toward the opening in the floor, boots slipping over the warped boards, while the bedroom leaned around them.

"Keep moving," Kai said.

"That isn't me."

"I know."

But the words sounded borrowed. They came out in Kai's voice, with the same clipped certainty he had heard from the reflection in the door. His shadow stretched ahead of him instead of behind, a black arm reaching toward the seam. Its fingers crawled over the floorboards, searching.

Sora stumbled. Kai caught him beneath the elbow and pulled harder. The scrape along Kai's palm opened against Sora's sleeve, wetting the fabric. The room smelled of dust and hot metal. Somewhere near the bed, the green-numbered alarm clock ticked beneath its casing, each click too slow to be a second.

The red-numbered clock still displayed 8:00 PM.

Kai glanced at it and nearly lost his grip.

The digits had become thin, crooked marks, but the time remained unmistakable. Eight. Zero. Zero. The phone in his pocket vibrated. He pulled it free without stopping.

8:00 PM glowed on the screen.

The battery percentage flickered from thirty-two to nineteen to a blank white square. In the black glass, his reflection looked directly at him. Its mouth moved before Kai's did.

"Let go of Sora."

Kai shoved the phone away.

"What did it say?" Sora asked.

"Nothing."

"You looked at it."

"Move."

The seam had narrowed. Beyond it lay no hallway now, only a vertical strip of darkness packed between two impossible surfaces. The floor rose around the opening like soft skin. Sora's fingers tightened around Kai's.

"Where are we going?" he asked.

"Out."

"Out where?"

Kai had no answer. He only knew the room had begun taking things from them. First the shapes of bodies. Then the direction of shadows. The moth had marked time against the window, and something beyond the glass had tapped back in Sora's rhythm. The thing in the seam had Kai's face. If the room could copy a face, it could copy anything.

Names, Kai thought.

The idea struck with such force that he stopped.

Sora slammed into his back. "What?"

"Your name."

Sora stared at him.

"Say it."

"What?"

"Your name. Say it."

The thing behind them made a soft sound. Not a footstep. A breath through teeth.

Sora's face tightened. "Sora."

Again, the sound came from the seam.

"Sora," said the voice wearing Kai's voice.

Kai turned his head.

The copy stood at the edge of the floor's opening. Its face was almost right. The eyes were too still, and the skin had the dull sheen of a reflection seen through dirty water. It lifted one hand.

"Sora," it repeated.

Sora pulled Kai toward the seam. "Don't listen."

"What if it's using the name?"

"What if it isn't?"

The question cut deeper than it should have. Kai looked at Sora's face, trying to find the details that belonged to him: the small white scar below his chin, the uneven fold of his left ear, the way he breathed through his nose when frightened. All of them were present. All of them felt suddenly like evidence planted for inspection.

"Tell me something only you would know," Kai said.

Sora's expression changed. "You already know my name."

"That isn't enough."

"You think I'm the copy?"

"I think the room is changing things."

"Then stop asking me questions and pull."

Kai did pull. He hauled Sora across the raised floor, toward the thin darkness. The seam gave under their weight with a damp, fibrous sound. Cold air touched Kai's face. It smelled like rain trapped inside a wall.

The shadow reached them first.

It slid over Sora's shoes and climbed his legs. Sora jerked away, but Kai held on.

"Don't let go," Kai said.

"My feet - "

"Don't."

The shadow wrapped around Kai's wrist. It was colder than the room, colder than the passage beyond the seam. Its touch carried a pressure, not pain but insistence, as if it knew the shape of his bones and wanted to correct them.

A word surfaced in Kai's mind.

Not his name. Someone else's.

He saw the neighbor slumped beside the bed, head bowed, one hand hanging limp over the carpet. The neighbor had been there for minutes or hours. Kai had never seen the face clearly. He had seen the cardigan, the gray hair, the chipped thumbnail. He had heard a name spoken before the room broke.

The name had mattered. It had been an anchor.

Kai twisted toward the bed.

"Sora, the neighbor."

"What about them?"

"Their name."

Sora's eyes shifted toward the slumped figure. "Why?"

"Say it."

"I don't know it."

"You heard it."

"So did you."

Kai searched his memory. The name had been ordinary. Two syllables, perhaps three. It had rested in his mind with the weight of something familiar, something he could use to pin the room in place.

He reached for it.

The copy whispered from behind him.

"Mar - "

Kai flinched.

His surname. Marlowe. The sound came wrong, stretched at the center, as though the room were tasting it.

The neighbor lifted their head.

Their face remained hidden in the pale spill beneath the bed, but their mouth moved.

"Call me - "

The rest vanished beneath the alarm clock's ticking.

Sora grabbed Kai's shoulder. "Don't answer."

"I need the name."

"You don't know what it is."

"I did."

"That's the point."

The shadow tightened around Kai's wrist. His fingers began to numb. He could feel the seam tugging at Sora, drawing him forward while the room pulled Kai backward. For one instant, Kai imagined releasing him. The choice was clean in his mind: let Sora fall into the dark, turn, and face the thing with his face. Perhaps the copy wanted Sora. Perhaps it only wanted Kai's place beside him.

Then Sora said, "Kai."

The name struck him like a hand across the mouth.

He looked at Sora.

"Stay with me," Sora said.

Kai drove his free hand into the floor.

The boards were warm and trembling. He found the cord of the green-numbered alarm clock beneath the bedframe, where it had been dragged during the room's last convulsion. The ticking pressed through the casing, frantic now, a swarm trapped in plastic.

Kai seized the cord and pulled.

The clock went silent.

Every red digit in the room vanished.

The copy's face collapsed.

Not changed. Collapsed, as if its features had been painted on wet paper. The eyes sank first, then the mouth, then the whole pale arrangement folded inward. The shadow released Kai's wrist.

"Now," Kai shouted.

He dragged Sora through the seam.

They landed on a hard surface that felt like wood but sounded like glass. Kai struck his shoulder and rolled. Sora came down beside him, coughing. Behind them, the seam began to close.

The bedroom remained visible through the narrowing gap.

The bedframe bowed over the slumped neighbor. The red clock was dark. The phone lay on the floor, its screen still glowing with 8:00 PM. In its reflection, Kai saw himself standing upright, though he was on his knees.

The neighbor reached toward the gap.

Kai crawled forward. "Wait."

Sora caught his ankle. "No."

"I need to know their name."

The neighbor's hand scraped the carpet. Their fingers bent backward one by one.

"Kai," Sora said, harder this time.

The gap shrank to the width of a hand. The neighbor lifted their face. For the first time, Kai saw it clearly: pale skin, wide eyes, lips cracked at the corners.

They spoke.

The word arrived without sound.

Kai felt it enter his head, bright and complete. A name. A real name. He knew it. He had known it before the clocks, before the moth, before the door opened the wrong way.

Then the room edited it.

The first syllable blurred. The second slid loose. The name became another name, then another, each one almost familiar. Kai clutched at the disappearing shape of it, but the harder he tried, the more it broke apart.

The seam sealed.

Sora pulled Kai upright. They stood in a narrow passage with walls on both sides, though neither wall had a visible surface. Cold pressed through Kai's clothes. Somewhere far away, the moth tapped against glass.

"What was it?" Sora asked.

Kai stared at the place where the bedroom had been.

"What was what?"

"The name."

He opened his mouth.

A name waited there.

Not the one he remembered. Not entirely.

It came out softly.

“Evan.”

Sora went still. “Who’s Evan?”

Kai felt the word settle on his tongue, smooth and wrong. He reached for the neighbor’s face, the cardigan, the hand beside the bed. The memory remained, but the name attached to it had torn loose.

“I don’t know,” he said.

Behind the wall, something answered in his voice.

“Evan.”

And from the darkness ahead, Sora whispered, “Kai,” though for one terrible second Kai could not remember whether that was his name or a warning.

CHAPTER 10

The Transition Void Opens Like Breath

“Kai,” Sora whispered again.

The sound came from the darkness ahead, but the voice behind the wall answered at the same time.

“Kai.”

His name struck him from both sides. One voice trembled with fear. The other wore his own tone too perfectly, calm and empty, as if it had practiced the word until it no longer meant anything.

Kai tightened his grip on Sora’s wrist.

The seam beneath them shivered. It ran across the bedroom floor in the shape of the moth’s path, a thin black line widening by fractions. White light leaked from one side. Darkness leaked from the other. Neither belonged to the room. The white was too bright to illuminate anything, and the black swallowed the red glow of the digital clock without reflecting it.

Sora’s fingers were cold.

“Don’t answer it,” she said.

“I’m not.”

“You already did.”

Kai opened his mouth. Nothing came out. His name had been in his head, though. He had felt it there, turning over like a loose tooth.

Behind Sora, the wall ripple bulged. The blank-faced shape pressed close beneath the plaster. Its outline had no edges now. It was only a thickness in the wall, a person-shaped absence with one hand raised against the other side.

The phone lay near Kai's shoe, its screen still showing 8:00 PM. The battery percentage had changed again. He remembered seeing sixty-three. Now it read 8.

The reflection in the black screen smiled a moment after he did not.

Sora pulled against him. "We have to move."

"Where?"

She looked toward the seam. "Through."

The word seemed to make the room contract. The bedframe gave a long wooden groan behind them. Its metal supports flexed, and the mattress rose and fell once, slowly, like something sleeping beneath it. The green-numbered alarm clock ticked beneath its casing. Each tick came from a different place: beside the bed, inside the wall, under Kai's tongue.

The digital clock flickered.

8:00 PM.

8:00 PM.

8:00 PM.

Then its red numbers rearranged themselves into a shape that resembled an open eye.

Kai dragged Sora backward. "That thing is in there."

"Which thing?"

He pointed to the wall.

The blank shape lifted its head. There were still no features, but Kai knew it was looking at him. He knew it because his own posture changed in the dark reflection of the door. The reflected Kai leaned forward, eager.

Sora's wrist jerked in his hand.

"Kai, listen to me." Her voice was low, urgent. "The seam is the only place it can't follow."

"How do you know?"

"I don't."

The answer stopped him.

For the first time since the room had begun changing, Sora looked less like someone who understood the rules and more like someone who had been pretending to. Her eyes stayed fixed on the widening break. White crawled across one edge of her face; black covered the other. Her features seemed to belong to two different versions of her, each waiting for the other to disappear.

"What's on the other side?" Kai asked.

Sora swallowed. "The next set."

"That doesn't mean anything."

"It means this room ends there."

The seam opened another inch.

A breath came through it.

The white side exhaled heat smelling of dust and hot metal. The black side exhaled cold, wet air carrying the faint odor of earth. Both currents pulled at Kai's clothes. Sora's hair lifted toward the gap, though no air moved anywhere else.

The wall spoke in Kai's voice.

"She doesn't know the way."

Sora flinched.

Kai looked at her. "What does that mean?"

"It means it wants you to ask."

"Then answer me."

"I can't."

The thing behind the wall pressed harder. A hairline crack appeared in the plaster above its hand. The crack spread upward, splitting the room's wallpaper into crooked branches. For an instant, Kai saw another bedroom through it. The same bed. The same clocks. Another Kai stood beside the window with his back turned.

Then the crack sealed.

Sora grabbed his sleeve. "Don't look at the walls."

"Why?"

"Because they show you where you could have gone."

The seam made a sound like fabric tearing underwater.

Its opening widened from floor to ceiling in one violent motion. The bedroom divided cleanly down the center. On the left, white poured upward, featureless and immense. On the right, black descended, deeper than the hallway beyond the door. The moth-marked line stretched between them, no longer a mark but a threshold.

The bedframe lurched.

Kai stumbled. His injured side struck the edge of the nightstand, sending pain through his ribs. The alarm clock toppled, its green numbers glowing against the floor. The ticking stopped.

Every distorted thing in the room went still.

Sora's grip tightened. "Now."

The wall shape moved.

It did not step out. The wall moved around it, peeling back in slow folds. A shoulder emerged, then an arm too long for the room. Where its hand touched the floor, the wood turned pale and soft.

Kai pulled Sora toward the seam.

The boundary resisted.

It felt like dragging her through deep water, except the water had fingers. Her wrist slid in his grasp. Her face blurred at the edges. For one instant, he saw Sora as a child, then as an old woman, then as a pale outline with no eyes.

"Kai," she said.

He almost let go.

The voice was hers, but beneath it ran another voice, whispering the same name backward.

He clamped both hands around her arm. "Stay with me."

"I am."

"No. Say it."

Sora stared at him. "I am Sora."

The room twitched.

The white half brightened until tears sprang into Kai's eyes. The black half thickened, folding over itself. The shape behind them made a sound like a laugh heard through a closed door.

Sora's expression changed.

"Kai Marlowe," she said.

His full name struck deeper than the voice wearing his face. It was a hook dropped into him. He felt the room catch on it.

The reflection in the door turned its head.

Kai Marlowe.

The shape behind the wall repeated him.

"Kai Marlowe."

His grip faltered.

Sora slapped his hand. "Don't listen to the echo."

"What if it's right?"

"Then it still isn't you."

The seam pulled open wider. Beyond it lay no hallway, no floor, no ceiling. The white and black sides met in a narrow vertical distance that seemed to extend forever. Between them drifted fragments of the bedroom: a corner of the bed, the red clock, a strip of wallpaper, the moth's pale wing. Each object moved slowly away, as if the void were breathing them out.

Kai understood then why Sora had called it the next set. It was not a place waiting beyond the room. It was the room after it had been taken apart.

The wall thing reached for Sora.

Its fingers crossed the threshold first.

Sora cried out. The sound tore into two voices. Her body jerked toward the wall while her feet remained planted. Kai saw the blank shape's hand wrapped around her shadow, not her flesh.

He seized her around the waist.

"Let go of me!"

"I'm trying!"

"Not me. The shadow!"

Kai looked down. Her shadow stretched across the floor toward the thing, thin as spilled ink. His own shadow had already detached once. It crouched beside his feet now, head bent, waiting.

He kicked it.

The impact made no sound, but the shadow recoiled. Sora's shadow snapped loose from the blank hand and whipped back beneath her.

The thing surged forward.

Kai shoved Sora across the seam.

She vanished to the waist.

The white light burned through her outline. The black took the rest. Her fingers clawed for him, and he caught them.

"Don't leave me," she said.

The words were barely audible.

Kai thought of the window tapping. The wrong-opening door. The thing wearing his face. He thought of Sora warning him not to move while the wall darkened, and of her hand locked around his wrist when his own shadow stepped away.

He had been waiting for certainty.

The room had never given anyone that.

"Kai," the thing said behind him.

He turned just enough to see his reflection standing in the open door. It had his face, his injuries, his blood-darkened sleeve. Its posture was colder, straighter. It lifted one hand toward Sora.

"Leave her," it said. "You can still go back."

The alarm clock began ticking again.

Once.

Twice.

On the third tick, the digital clock flashed 8:01 PM.

The room screamed.

Kai pulled.

Sora came free with a wet tearing sound, though no blood followed. Her body slammed against his chest. He wrapped one arm around her and drove his shoulder into the seam.

The boundary folded around them.

For a moment, he was nowhere. White pressed against his left eye. Black filled his right. Sora's nails dug into his neck. Something cold touched the back of his skull and began searching for a place to enter.

Then his foot struck a hard surface.

Kai fell forward, dragging Sora with him.

They landed on a floor that felt like painted wood and breathed warm beneath his palms. Sora hit beside him, coughing. The air smelled of rain trapped inside concrete. Somewhere ahead, a light buzzed without shining.

Kai rolled onto his back.

The seam stood behind them, vertical and narrow, white on one edge and black on the other. Through it he saw the bedroom split down the middle. The bedframe bent toward the opening. The clocks hung in the air. The shape wearing his face stood in the doorway, one hand resting on the handle.

Its reflection looked back from the dark surface.

Both versions smiled.

The seam began to close.

Sora pushed herself upright. "Kai."

He reached for her, but her hand was already sliding away. The floor tilted toward the narrowing boundary. Beyond Sora's shoulder lay a corridor assembled from pieces of places he recognized: the bedroom door, the window passage, a strip of wall with the moth mark crawling across it. At the far end, something tapped three times.

Sora grabbed his sleeve. "Don't let it separate us."

"I won't."

The void snapped shut behind their shoulders.

The sound was soft.

Almost gentle.

Then the corridor lights came on, one after another, revealing two sets of footprints ahead.

One belonged to Kai.

The other was still wet.

CHAPTER 11

White Noise, Black Edges

One belonged to Kai.

The other was still wet.

He stared at the two footprints suspended beneath them, each dark enough to reflect the pale blur of his knees. They did not touch any floor. The seam had snapped shut behind him and Sora with a sound like a mouth biting through wire, leaving only a narrow strip of nothing beneath their shoes.

Sora's hand was still around his wrist.

"Don't look down," Sora said.

Kai looked down again.

The footprints shifted. One turned toward him. The other pointed away.

He pulled free and reached for Sora's sleeve instead. His scraped palm burned where the bedframe had opened it, and the cut along his forearm had begun to stiffen beneath his sleeve. "We need to move."

"Where?"

"That's the problem."

There was no room, no wall, no ceiling. The Transition Void stretched in every direction, black at the center and white at its edges, though Kai could not tell whether the white was light or the memory of light. Their bodies seemed to occupy a corridor

that vanished whenever he tried to measure it. The last thing behind them had been the room, the clocks, the bed that breathed. Ahead waited nothing he could name.

Then the whispers began.

At first they sounded like radio static leaking through a closed door. A thin hiss threaded from the dark, rose, and fell. Beneath it came another voice, then another, each buried under the next.

"Kai."

He flinched.

Sora tightened his grip. "Don't answer."

The voice came again from somewhere ahead.

"Kai, this way."

Another whispered from the left.

"Kai, don't move."

A third breathed directly beside his ear.

"Kai."

He turned so fast his shoulder struck Sora's chest.

Sora's face was there, but the edges of it trembled, breaking into pale horizontal bands before settling again. "Which one did you hear?"

"All of them."

"That isn't possible."

"Neither was your shadow walking away."

Sora looked past him. In the darkness, something made a soft clicking noise, like fingernails testing glass. "We need a direction."

Kai listened. The whispers overlapped until language became texture. Some were high and dry, like insects trapped behind a wall. Others dragged low through the dark, carrying the weight of a voice heard underwater. Every few seconds, one separated from the rest and formed a word.

Back.

Near.

Sora.

Kai.

The words did not come from fixed places. They moved around him. A whisper that had seemed ten feet ahead suddenly brushed his neck. Another rose beneath his shoes, though there was still no floor.

Sora stepped forward.

Kai caught him. "Wait."

"That one said my name."

"So did the thing wearing my face."

Sora's expression tightened. He glanced toward the place where the seam had been. There was no sign of it now, only a faint vertical brightness hanging in the dark. "If we stay here, it will find us."

"What will?"

Sora did not answer.

The static thickened. A voice emerged from it, warm and familiar.

"Kai, it's me."

Sora went still.

Kai knew that voice. It was Sora's voice, but not the voice beside him. This one carried the tired softness Sora used before the room changed, before the wall ripple, before he had said Evan and looked at Kai as if the name belonged to someone else.

"Come back," the voice said. "The door is open."

Kai's injured hand began to tremble.

Sora whispered, "That isn't me."

The voice laughed under the static. "He says that now."

A pale shape appeared to Kai's right. It looked like the edge of a doorway, except its corners bent inward, making the opening narrower at the middle. Beyond it, something white flickered. Kai saw a strip of wallpaper. A brass handle. The dark surface of the bedroom door.

His body leaned toward it before he could stop himself.

Sora seized the back of his shirt. "No."

"It's showing the room."

"It's showing what you want."

The doorway folded shut. Its edges slid past each other without touching, and the image of the door remained for one second between them, reflected in the black. Kai saw himself standing there with his hand on the handle.

The reflection was smiling.

He jerked backward.

The void answered with a burst of sound. Every whisper spoke at once.

The noise struck him physically. His teeth clicked together. His scraped palm opened again, warm wetness spreading across his fingers. Sora shouted something, but the words broke apart before reaching him.

Kai pressed both hands over his ears.

It made no difference.

The voices were inside his skull now, layered so densely that he could feel their separate rhythms. One repeated his name. One counted down from eight. One murmured a sentence he could almost understand.

The loudest voice was not the deepest. It was the one nearest.

"Kai."

He forced his eyes open.

The shapes around him had changed. Thin black edges floated in the white, outlining objects that could not exist: a chair with three backs, a window opening onto another window, a staircase seen from its underside. They drifted in and out of alignment. When Kai focused on one, it stretched away. When he looked aside, it snapped closer.

A black line passed through Sora's shoulder.

Sora did not react.

Kai grabbed him and pulled. His fingers met resistance, then slipped through the place where the edge had crossed him. Sora's outline shuddered.

"Kai," Sora said. His mouth moved a fraction after the sound. "Stop touching me."

"You were splitting."

"So were you."

Kai looked at his own arm. From wrist to elbow, a white border traced the skin, too straight to be a reflection. It pulsed with the whispers.

The voice nearest him spoke again.

"Kai."

This time it came from beneath Sora's feet.

Sora heard it too. His eyes dropped.

"No," Kai said.

The black beneath them opened into a shallow square. Not a hole. A surface. On it, the two wet footprints appeared again, walking away one after the other.

Sora backed up. "We need to follow a sound before the void gives us another choice."

"Which sound?"

"The one that doesn't know our names."

Kai listened through the static. Voices called from every side, offering doors, rooms, memories. One whispered about the green-numbered clock ticking beneath its casing. Another imitated the digital clock's flat red glow. A third spoke in his own voice and described the cut in his hand.

Then, beneath them all, he heard a faint repeating tone.

Not a word.

A click. A pause. A click.

The alarm clock.

Kai turned toward it.

Sora caught his arm. "That could be bait."

“Everything is bait.”

The clicking came again, farther away. It had the same uneven rhythm as before, when the alarm clock had ticked beneath its casing and the bed had breathed in around him. The sound was wrong, but it repeated without changing. The whispers changed. They bent around him, tried different voices, grew sharper whenever he moved.

The clicking did not.

Kai took one step.

The void shifted.

A white edge flashed across his vision. For an instant, the corridor ahead filled with doors. Some stood upright. Some lay flat against the dark. One opened onto the bedroom, where the bedframe lifted and lowered like a rib cage.

Sora said, “Kai, stop.”

The clicking continued.

Kai took another step.

The doors slammed shut without sound. Their black edges remained, hovering in the white. The whispers surged toward him.

“Wrong way.”

“Come here.”

“Behind you.”

He kept walking.

Sora followed, but his hand no longer held Kai’s wrist. Their shoulders brushed once, then the space between them widened. Kai reached back and found only cold.

"Sora?"

"Keep going."

His voice came from ahead.

Kai stopped.

The clicking had moved behind him.

Sora's voice came again, this time from the right. "Keep going."

A third Sora whispered from the left. "Kai, please."

Kai turned in a slow circle. The white around him had become almost bright enough to show detail. Black outlines crowded it now, forming the edges of impossible structures. A wall rose without thickness. A staircase descended into its own first step. Something with too many corners leaned toward him, then withdrew when he looked directly at it.

"Sora," Kai called.

All the voices answered.

He shut his eyes.

The void pressed cold against his face. He remembered the wall ripple and the shape behind Sora lifting its blank face. He remembered the stranger wearing his own face stepping into the seam. He remembered the wet footprint that belonged to him, and the other one that had not.

The real Sora had always warned him too late.

The copies warned him exactly when he wanted to hear it.

Kai opened his eyes and listened for the voice that did not use his name.

Nothing.

The clicking had stopped.

In its place came a faint scrape, steady and granular, like shoes crossing tile.

He followed it.

Each step cost him balance. The edges around him slid past, sometimes close enough to graze his sleeve. One black line nicked his cheek. He felt the sting, then saw a thin white mark appear on his skin instead of blood.

Behind him, Sora shouted, "Kai, don't follow that!"

The shout carried panic. Real panic, perhaps. Or an excellent imitation.

Kai kept moving.

The scrape grew louder. The white glare narrowed. Darkness gathered on both sides, no longer empty but vertical, like walls waiting to be recognized.

He reached out.

His fingers struck a hard surface.

Tile.

The corridor appeared all at once.

It was thin, barely wide enough for two people. Alternating white and black tiles ran ahead in a straight line, each square too clean, too sharply edged. No walls enclosed it, yet the darkness on either side held firm. Above, there was only white noise, a ceiling made of hiss.

Kai stepped onto the first white tile.

The whispers fell silent.

Behind him, Sora breathed, "You found it."

Kai looked back.

Sora stood several paces away, one foot on the black square beside the corridor. His face was turned toward Kai, but his shadow faced the other direction.

The loudest whisper rose from somewhere deep along the tiled passage.

"Kai."

Sora's hand lifted. "Don't."

Kai looked at the black edge beneath Sora's foot. It was wet.

The whisper called again, louder now, drawing him forward.

Kai stepped onto the next white tile.

Sora's shadow moved before Sora did.

Kai followed the sound.

CHAPTER 12

Sora's Silence Turns into a Warning

Kai followed the sound with his hand pressed against the corridor wall, fingers sliding over plaster that felt damp and faintly warm. Sora's shadow had moved before she did. It stretched ahead of her now, thin as spilled ink, pointing down the corridor.

Kai stepped after it.

The floor changed beneath his shoe.

Not cracked. Not broken. Changed. The dark tile beneath him lightened from gray to a dull, milky white, its surface shining as if something wet had been poured beneath the glaze. Ahead, the tiles alternated in a straight line: black, white, black, white, vanishing into a narrow darkness where the corridor seemed to fold away.

Sora jerked both hands toward him.

Stop.

Her mouth formed the word, but no sound came. The silence around her had thickened since the wall ripple swallowed her voice. Even her breathing made no noise. Kai could see her chest rising. He could see the tremor in her fingers. Nothing reached him.

He lifted one hand.

Sora shook her head hard enough to send loose strands of hair across her face. Then she pointed at the floor and drew her finger sharply across her throat.

Kai looked down.

His left shoe hovered over the edge of the next tile. Beneath the sole, the white square gave a tiny pulse. The light inside it traveled outward in a perfect ring, stopped at the grout, and withdrew.

The corridor smelled of wet stone and hot metal. Somewhere behind them, something ticked beneath a casing.

Kai thought of the green-numbered alarm clock, ticking where no clock should have been. He thought of the red numbers fixed at 8:00 PM, and his phone reflecting a version of him that had not moved when he moved. The corridor had appeared after the room broke open. If the tiles were another rule, he needed to know it.

More than that, he needed Sora moving.

The darkness behind her had begun to ripple.

He lowered his foot onto the tile he occupied. Sora seized his sleeve and pulled him backward. Her grip was weak, but panic gave it shape. She pointed toward the alternating path, then back toward the corridor behind them. Her eyes asked the question her silent mouth could not.

Which way?

Kai glanced over his shoulder.

The way they had come was no longer the same corridor. The wall leaned inward, narrowing the passage by inches. At its far end, the darkness trembled like a reflection disturbed by a fingertip. Something pale shifted inside it.

Sora tapped her wrist.

Time.

The red clock's digits flashed behind Kai's eyes. 8:00 PM. Still 8:00 PM. Always 8:00 PM.

He turned back to the tiles.

"I need to find out what they do," he whispered.

His voice sounded wrong. It came from the floor instead of his throat, flattened and distant. Sora's expression tightened.

Kai pointed at the white tile. Then at the black one. He held up two fingers and spread them apart.

Sora slapped his hand down.

The movement was so sharp that Kai flinched. Her palm remained against his wrist. She shook her head again, more violently this time, and pointed to the tile without touching it.

Don't touch the tiles.

The warning was clear enough now.

Kai stared at the white square. Its surface reflected his shoe, but the reflection showed the sole already planted on the tile ahead. In the reflection, his leg was bent at a different angle. His body leaned toward the corridor's darkness.

He pulled his foot back.

The reflected shoe stayed where it was.

A soft click sounded beneath the tile.

Sora's hand tightened around him.

Kai crouched, ignoring the scrape in his ribs and the raw skin beneath his shirt. He leaned toward the grout. A narrow line of black ran between the squares, too deep for

grout, descending into a darkness that seemed to have no floor beneath it.

“What are you hiding?” he murmured.

The tile answered with a faint vibration.

Sora dragged him upright. She pointed at herself, then at the corridor ahead, then made a walking motion with two fingers. Her meaning came through in pieces: she would go first. He should follow exactly.

Kai shook his head.

She had already vanished once behind a wall that called his name in his own voice. He would not let her step onto a path he did not understand.

Sora’s eyes hardened. She thrust one finger toward the black tile.

Kai looked.

A thin wet mark crossed its surface. It resembled a footprint, but the toes pointed backward.

His stomach turned.

The mark appeared again on the next black tile, farther down. Then another. Each footprint led toward the darkness. None led back.

Sora saw him notice. Her face lost what little color remained.

Kai pointed to the prints, then to the dark end of the corridor.

“Something walked there,” he said.

The corridor gave him his words back.

Something walked there.

The echo came from behind Sora.

She spun. Her shadow did not. It remained aimed at the tiles, its long arm stretching across the floor toward the nearest white square.

Kai grabbed Sora's shoulder and pulled her around. Her shadow snapped back beneath her feet a moment later.

The wall behind them bulged.

Not outward like a body pressing through. Inward, as if the plaster had become skin and something on the other side had drawn a breath. A faint outline appeared beneath it: a face without features, then the impression of fingers dragging downward.

Sora pointed ahead.

Kai understood. The corridor behind them was closing.

He looked from the advancing wall to the alternating tiles. His urge to test the pattern rose fast and bright. If black was safe, they could move. If white was safe, they could move. If the tiles reacted to weight, perhaps the grout could carry them. There had to be a rule.

He needed the rule before the corridor took them.

Sora caught his face between both hands. Her fingers were cold. She forced his eyes to hers and mouthed, No.

Not no to the corridor. No to him.

Kai glanced down again.

The reflection in the white tile had changed. Its head tilted toward Sora. Its mouth opened.

Sora's mouth stayed closed.

The reflected version of her whispered something Kai could not hear.

He reached toward the tile.

Sora struck his hand away.

The air above the white square shuddered.

Kai's fingers had never touched it. They were still several inches above the surface, but the tile darkened under them. A thin line of frost spread from its center. The corridor's temperature dropped so suddenly that his breath appeared.

Sora recoiled.

The tile made a dry, electrical hiss.

Kai snatched his hand back.

For one second nothing happened.

Then the black tile behind them flashed white.

The wall bulged farther into the corridor.

Sora grabbed Kai's coat and pulled him toward the next square. Her boots crossed the grout without touching either color. Kai followed, stepping only where she stepped, both of them balancing along the narrow seams.

The corridor groaned.

A sound like wood bending came from beneath the floor. The white tile ahead lifted at one corner. Under it was not concrete or darkness, but a cramped glimpse of the bedroom: the bedframe crouched on its warped legs, the alarm clock glowing green beneath it, its casing ticking.

Kai nearly lost his balance.

The bedframe's metal slats flexed as though breathing. Beneath it, something crawled past the clock. A pale hand dragged along the floor and disappeared.

Sora waved him on.

Kai moved sideways, one foot on the grout, one palm against the wall. The plaster was slick now. It left a cold residue on his skin. Sora reached the next seam and stopped.

Ahead, the corridor split.

The alternating tiles continued left, but to the right the floor became a single unbroken black surface. At the junction stood a narrow door with no handle. Its dark face reflected Kai.

The reflection stood perfectly still.

Kai did not.

He watched it raise one hand.

The figure in the door pressed its palm against the other side of the glass.

Sora pointed left.

Kai pointed at the door.

Her head snapped toward him. She mouthed something with fierce urgency.

No door.

The reflection smiled.

Kai felt the old pull in his chest, the same need that had made him try the handle before. Answers were always close in this place. They waited behind surfaces, beneath clocks, inside the wrong versions of him. If he refused to look, the corridor would choose for him.

He extended his hand toward the nearest white tile instead.

Sora's eyes widened.

Kai stopped with his fingers hovering above the glaze.

He could feel heat rising from it. Not warmth. Breath. The tile seemed to inhale toward his hand, drawing at the skin along his fingertips.

"What happens if I don't touch you?" he asked.

The tile pulsed.

The reflection in the door moved first. It turned its head toward the black surface on the right.

A second reflection appeared beside it.

Then a third.

All of them wore Kai's face. None of them had the same posture.

Sora seized his wrist and yanked him away.

Kai resisted for half a second. That was all it took.

The white tile flipped.

Its color drained from the center outward, changing to a deep, glossy black. The surface folded with a sharp click, though nothing physical moved. A hiss burst from the square, loud enough to make Kai's teeth ache.

Sora stumbled backward.

The black footprints ahead filled with water.

One by one, they began to move.

Not footprints now. Impressions. Something invisible pressed down into each tile as it approached them, leaving wet marks in the shape of backward toes. The sound came

with it: a soft dragging scrape, then another, then another.

Kai pulled Sora toward the wall.

The corridor behind them sealed shut.

The bulging plaster flattened with a wet slap. No seam remained. No opening. Only the faint outline of a hand beneath the paint, fingers spread at shoulder height.

Sora struck the wall with both fists. No sound came from the impact. Her mouth opened in a scream Kai could not hear.

The activated tile hissed again.

A line of black traveled from it along the grout, racing toward their feet.

Kai looked at Sora. She was still pounding the wall, trapped between silence and the approaching dark.

He hooked an arm around her waist and dragged her toward the right-hand passage. The black surface there rippled under his shoe but did not change color. The door without a handle waited at the end.

Sora fought him, pointing back at the tiles.

The wet impressions had stopped.

They formed a line around the square Kai had nearly touched.

Then the white tile beneath the black glaze split down the middle.

Something beneath it whispered in Sora's voice.

"Kai."

He froze.

Sora went rigid against him.

The voice came again, closer this time, from under the floor.

“Kai, don’t let me out.”

Sora’s hand found his.

Her fingers squeezed once.

Not a plea. A warning.

The door at the end of the black passage reflected them both. In its surface, Sora was standing alone. Kai was nowhere beside her.

Then the reflected Sora turned toward the tiles and raised one silent finger to her lips.

Behind Kai, the activated square began to open.

The Cat That Isn't There

“Don't step on the pale ones,” Sora said.

Her voice came from somewhere behind Kai, thin and scraped raw. He turned toward it, but the corridor had already changed. The square behind him was no longer opening. It had become a black seam between tiles, narrow as a shut eye.

Sora stood near the bend, one hand against the wall. The reflected Sora was gone. Only the real one remained, her face drained beneath the corridor's wavering light.

Kai looked down at the floor.

The tiles changed pattern ahead. Behind him, they were small gray squares, damp around the edges. Near the bend, they lengthened into dark rectangles veined with white. The pale ones Sora meant were not pale at all. They were the color of old teeth, each one shining faintly as if something beneath it were breathing.

“I'm not stepping anywhere until you tell me what happened,” Kai said.

Sora's mouth opened. No sound came out.

The corridor answered for her.

A soft brush touched Kai's ankle.

He flinched so hard his shoulder struck the wall. Cold fur slid against his skin, followed by the quick pressure of a small body winding around his leg. Something bumped his calf. He heard the faint click of claws on tile.

Kai stared down.

There was nothing there.

The sensation remained.

It moved from his right ankle to his left, circling him with deliberate patience. Fur grazed his trouser cuff. A warm flank pressed against his shin. The smell arrived a moment later: dust, rainwater, and the stale sweetness of an animal that had slept beneath furniture.

“Sora.”

She lifted one finger.

Kai held still. The invisible creature brushed him again. Its tail, or the idea of one, passed over the back of his ankle.

Sora pointed at the pale tiles.

The corridor gave a low creak. Not from the walls. From beneath the floor.

Kai swallowed. “Is it real?”

Sora shook her head once, then hesitated. Her expression tightened as if the answer had split before reaching her.

“Guide?” he asked.

Her lips moved. The first sound broke apart in her throat.

The invisible cat rubbed against him.

Kai glanced toward the bend. Beyond it, the corridor narrowed into darkness. The walls leaned inward there, their wallpaper puckered in long vertical folds. A red glow pulsed somewhere out of sight, steady as the digital clock’s impossible 8:00 PM.

Beneath that glow came a faint ticking, green and muffled, like the alarm clock trapped under its casing.

The cat began to walk.

Its weight pressed against Kai's ankle, pulling him toward the bend.

He resisted. The sensation tugged harder.

"No," Sora whispered.

It was the first complete word she had spoken since the corridor swallowed them.

Kai looked at her. "No to the cat?"

Sora's eyes fixed on the floor. "Tiles."

The word came out wet and uneven. She gripped the wall with both hands.

Kai lowered his gaze. The dark rectangular tile directly ahead had changed. A thin line of moisture spread across it, forming the outline of four small paw prints. One appeared. Then another. Then another, each mark sinking into the surface without leaving a depression.

The cat stepped onto the tile.

Nothing showed except the prints.

Kai reached for Sora. His fingers closed around her wrist, finding her pulse racing beneath cold skin.

"We go back," he said.

Behind them, the corridor had lost its beginning.

There was no opening to the room, no rippling floor, no black seam. The wall ran unbroken from one corner to the other, its plaster damp and faintly warm beneath

Kai's free hand. A dark stain shaped like a doorway quivered in the middle of it, but when he pushed against the stain, his palm met solid plaster.

Sora tried to speak. Her breath caught.

The cat brushed Kai's ankle again.

This time, its purr entered through the floor.

The sound was barely audible, a vibration more than a noise. It traveled up his bones and settled behind his teeth. With each pulse, the corridor shifted by a fraction. The walls slid closer, then eased away. The pale tiles brightened. The dark ones seemed to deepen beneath his shoes.

Kai pulled Sora toward the bend.

She dug in her heels. "Not - "

The rest vanished.

Her hand slipped from the wall, and one of the pale tiles cracked beneath her heel.

Something moved inside the crack.

Kai saw a strip of darkness, narrow and wet, flexing like a pupil. He jerked Sora backward. Her heel came free. The crack sealed with a soft click.

For a moment neither of them moved.

Then the corridor behind them exhaled.

The wall bulged outward. Wallpaper peeled from it in a slow wave, revealing not plaster but a depthless black filled with pale flecks. They drifted behind the surface like dust underwater.

Sora stared at it.

"Kai," she said.

Her voice was clearer now.

"What?"

She pointed at the wall. "It took the room."

The purr stopped.

Silence dropped over the corridor so completely that Kai heard the blood moving in his ears.

The invisible cat vanished from his ankle.

He almost stumbled from the sudden absence.

A tiny meow sounded ahead, around the bend.

Kai tightened his grip on Sora. "That's not a guide."

Sora looked at him. Her pupils were wide. "Then what?"

He wanted to say symptom. He wanted to say the void had learned the shape of an animal because animals belonged in hallways, under beds, beside warm radiators. He wanted the sensation to be nothing more than another theft of matter, like the reflections that moved before their bodies or the room that had disappeared behind them.

But the smell of dust and rain still clung to his clothes.

And there was something else now.

A faint warmth remained against his ankle, precisely where the cat had touched him.

"We find out," Kai said.

Sora's hand caught his sleeve. "Kai, don't."

He looked down at her fingers. "You said the tiles."

"I said don't."

The word trembled, but it held.

Around the bend, the meow came again.

Kai stepped onto the dark tile marked by the invisible paw prints.

The corridor lurched.

Sora cried out and seized his arm. The wall beside them stretched, carrying the bend farther away. The red glow ahead smeared into a long vertical wound. Underneath it, the green ticking grew louder.

Kai's shoe sank half an inch into the tile.

He felt something soft beneath the sole.

Not flesh. Not stone.

Fur.

He yanked his foot back. The tile released it with a damp sigh.

Sora pulled him toward the wall. "Stay where the pattern changes."

"What does that mean?"

Her face twisted. She pressed one hand to her throat. "It means - "

The corridor snapped.

For one instant Kai stood in the bedroom again. The digital clock glowed red on the nightstand. The bedframe rose and fell. The alarm clock ticked beneath its casing. Sora stood beside the window, her hand lifted toward the moth.

Then the image folded shut.

Kai was back in the corridor, but Sora was no longer beside him.

Her fingers still clutched his sleeve.

The rest of her stood three feet away.

Kai stared at the impossible separation. Her hand remained attached to him by the sleeve, her arm stretching too far, skin drawn tight and pale. Sora's body leaned against the wall, mouth open in a silent scream.

He grabbed her wrist and pulled.

The corridor resisted.

The fabric of his sleeve tightened around his arm. His injured skin burned where the scrape from beneath the bedframe had reopened. Warm blood slipped beneath the cuff.

"Sora!"

Her body jerked toward him. The hand on his sleeve stayed fixed.

The invisible cat began purring again.

This time the purr carried words.

They were buried inside the vibration, shaped by it rather than spoken. Kai heard fragments sliding beneath the sound.

Not the room.

Not the wall.

Not - Sora's lips moved in time with the purring.

"Let go," she said.

Kai looked at her. "What?"

"Let go."

He released her wrist.

The stretched arm snapped back. Sora slammed against the wall, and the hand gripping his sleeve disappeared. Kai staggered forward, nearly stepping onto a pale tile.

Sora caught herself and raised both hands.

"Stop."

He stopped.

The cat circled his feet. Invisible fur brushed his calves. Its purr had become a low, steady current running through the floor.

Sora pointed at the junction ahead, where the dark rectangles met the pale squares.

"There," she said. "The pattern."

Kai saw it now. The tiles did not alternate randomly. The dark ones formed a path, but the path doubled back on itself. Every third tile was pale, and each pale tile held the faintest impression of something pressed beneath it.

A paw.

A hand.

Once, unmistakably, the outline of Kai's own face.

The corridor was not leading them toward the cat. It was arranging them around it.

Kai took the phone from his pocket. The screen flickered awake at 8:00 PM. His reflection stared back, but its head was tilted at the wrong angle. The battery

percentage changed from forty-three to eight, then to nothing.

The phone vibrated.

A new reflection appeared beside his.

Small. Low to the ground.

Two bright eyes hovered near the bottom of the screen.

Kai dropped the phone.

It struck the dark tile and did not bounce. The glass remained visible, sunk beneath the surface as if the floor had become water. The cat's eyes stared up through it.

Sora whispered, "Matter."

Kai crouched, keeping his weight on the safe tile. "What?"

"It's taking matter."

The phone slid deeper.

He reached for it.

Sora seized the back of his coat. "Kai, no."

The phone vanished.

A red glow spread beneath the tile, and from somewhere below came the digital clock's flat electronic chirp. Eight o'clock. Then eight o'clock again.

Kai rose slowly. "It took the phone."

"No." Sora's voice shook. "It took what the phone remembered."

The cat's eyes disappeared beneath the floor.

A cold pressure touched Kai's ankle.

He looked down.

The absence had taken shape.

There was a hollow in the air beside his leg, the outline of a small body defined only by what the corridor failed to show. Dust bent around it. Moisture gathered along an invisible back. Four paw prints appeared on the tile, darkening one by one.

The cat was not there.

Something had made room for it.

Kai understood then why the sensation felt so exact. The void did not invent touch. It removed everything except the evidence that touch had happened.

The invisible head pressed against his hand.

He reached down.

Sora made a strangled sound. "Kai."

His fingers met warmth.

For half a second, he felt a skull beneath fur, a small ear folding beneath his palm. The purr deepened, and the corridor's walls shuddered.

Then the fur vanished.

His hand closed around nothing.

The cat's purr continued inside his chest.

Sora stepped away from the wall. Her face had changed. Fear remained, but beneath it was recognition.

"It's speaking," she said.

Kai turned toward her. "What is it saying?"

Sora listened.

The purr pulsed once.

She answered with a single word.

"Behind."

Kai looked over his shoulder.

The corridor behind him was empty.

Then a soft purr sounded directly at his back.

Sora turned toward it, eyes fixed on the space above his shoulder. Her mouth opened. The word fought its way out, rough but whole.

"Run."

CHAPTER 14

One Word Opens the Wrong Door

“K ai.”

The word scraped out of Sora’s throat and struck the corridor like a thrown stone.

Kai felt it before he understood it. The wall beneath his palm shuddered. Plaster tightened under his fingers, then slid sideways with a wet, granular sound. The floor tilted just enough to send a pale tile skittering past his shoe. Somewhere behind them, the alarm clock began ticking beneath its casing.

Sora stared at him.

Her lips trembled. A thread of blood marked the corner of her mouth. “I said your name.”

“You said it once before.”

“I know.”

The corridor had been narrow a moment ago, its walls running ahead into a gray distance that refused to get closer. Now the distance folded inward. Lines appeared in the plaster, straight and black, drawing themselves from ceiling to floor. A rectangle opened where there had been no door, no frame, not even a seam.

Kai tightened his grip around Sora’s wrist. Her skin was cold, but her pulse beat hard against his thumb.

“Don’t say anything else,” he whispered.

The new shape widened.

Not opened. Widened.

The corridor rearranged itself around the sound of her word. Tiles slid into place beneath the gap. The ceiling lowered above it, forming a lintel. On the other side waited darkness so complete it looked solid.

Sora's eyes moved over the edges. "It listened."

Kai remembered the floor rippling upward like a doorway. He remembered the thing wearing his face stepping into the seam. He remembered Sora telling him not to move while his own shadow stood apart from his feet.

The gap had the same wrong geometry, but this time it had answered her.

"Can you do it again?" he asked.

Her gaze snapped to his. "You just told me not to."

"To say the word. Not another one."

"I don't know what it does."

"It made a door."

"It made something shaped like a door."

Behind them, the corridor gave a low creak. The pale tiles began turning over one by one, their undersides black and damp. The sound traveled toward them in a steady line.

Kai looked at the gap. Safety had to be somewhere beyond it. The corridor had already taken the room, the window, the bedframe, every fixed thing they had trusted. If language could force the void to make a passage, it was the first useful rule they had found.

He wanted the two of them on the other side. Together. Before the corridor folded again.

"Sora," he said, keeping his voice low, "we can't stay here."

Her fingers closed around his. "If it separates us?"

"Then I'll pull you through."

"You said that last time."

He had. His hand had been locked around her wrist when his shadow stepped away. He had still almost lost her.

The ticking drew nearer.

Kai moved toward the gap.

The black surface did not reflect him. That frightened him more than the absence of a floor beyond it. Every dark thing in this place had returned a version of his face, a posture delayed by a beat or lit by a colder light. This darkness offered nothing. No Kai. No Sora. No shape waiting to imitate them.

The first pale tile behind his heel cracked.

Sora pulled him back. "Wait."

Kai stopped. "For what?"

"For it to show us what it wants."

"It already showed us."

"No. It showed us an opening."

The gap's edges twitched. The left side leaned inward, narrowing like a mouth deciding whether to bite. The right side stretched, and for an instant Kai saw the

bedroom through it: the digital clock glowing red, 8:00 PM. The bedframe crouched beside the wall. The moth hung above the window, its wings marking time.

Then the image snapped away.

Sora made a small sound.

"What did you see?"

"Nothing."

"Sora."

Her face had gone gray. "The room."

"Was it real?"

"It was behind us."

Kai turned.

The corridor had changed. The place where they had come from was gone. A wall stood there now, smooth and unbroken, except for a dark wet streak running down it at shoulder height. His handprint remained in the plaster, fingers spread as if someone had pressed them from the other side.

The ticking stopped.

A second later, it began inside the wall.

Kai felt the sound in his teeth.

"We're out of time," he said.

Sora shook her head. "That's what it wants."

"What does?"

"The word."

The gap shivered.

Kai's mouth went dry. "It opened when you said my name."

"It may not have opened for you."

"Then who?"

Sora looked past him, toward the blank wall. "Something that knows it."

The ticking became faster. Not louder. Faster, each click crowding the next until it sounded like fingernails racing over glass.

The black gap deepened.

A smell drifted from it, sharp and mineral, like rain trapped in a sealed basement. Cold spilled across Kai's shoes. It crawled up his legs beneath his jeans.

Sora's grip tightened. "Don't let go."

"I won't."

"Even if you hear me."

Kai looked at her. "What does that mean?"

"Even if you hear me calling from somewhere else."

The wall behind them bulged.

A shallow outline appeared in it: shoulder, head, one arm raised. The shape pressed from within, flattening the plaster without breaking through.

Kai pulled Sora toward the gap.

She resisted for half a second, then moved with him. Their shoes struck the rearranged tiles. Each step made the corridor twitch. The ceiling stretched higher. The door-shaped opening grew narrower.

"Kai," Sora whispered.

The gap reacted.

Its black interior rippled once.

Kai stopped so abruptly Sora collided with his back. "You said it again."

"I didn't."

He turned.

Her mouth was closed.

From inside the gap, her voice said, "Kai."

The sound came softly, almost tenderly. It carried the exact roughness in her throat, the same damaged edge. But Sora stood beside him, silent, her breath cold against his sleeve.

The voice came again.

"Kai."

The opening widened by an inch.

Sora's eyes filled with terror. "It learned me."

The shape in the wall pushed harder. A finger emerged through the plaster, pale and jointed wrong. It bent toward them.

Kai faced the gap. "Then we go now."

"No."

"If we stay, it gets out."

"You don't know that."

"I know the corridor is closing."

The pale tiles behind them were vanishing beneath a spreading black stain. The wall-shape had forced out a second finger. Its nails scraped the plaster with a dry, patient sound.

Kai stepped forward.

The gap opened.

Not into another corridor. Not into the bedroom.

The darkness parted around him, and a narrow strip of floor appeared beneath his foot. It looked like the tiles they had crossed, but the surface was soft enough to give under his weight. Something cold brushed his ankle from below.

Sora caught his coat. "Kai, stop."

He tried to pull back.

His foot would not move.

The black floor had closed around his shoe. It was not gripping him; it was holding him with the pressure of deep water. He tugged harder. Pain shot through the scrape along his shin, and the wound opened beneath his jeans.

Sora wrapped both hands around his arm. "Pull!"

Kai leaned backward. The corridor groaned. For one second his shoe came free, then the gap shifted and swallowed the space behind his heel.

The voice inside whispered, "Kai."

The word struck him like a command.

His other foot moved forward.

He had not chosen to step. His knee bent, his weight transferred, and the gap drew him in.

Sora made a strangled sound and seized his wrist. Her nails cut through his sleeve. "Look at me."

Kai turned his head.

Her face was beside his, but the light on it was wrong. It came from beneath her chin, cold and bluish, making her eyes appear too deep. Behind her, the wall-shape had opened a slit where its mouth should be.

"Kai," it said in Sora's voice.

Sora slapped Kai across the face.

The blow cracked through the corridor.

His foot jerked free.

They fell backward together. Kai struck the tiles, and Sora landed across his chest. The gap snapped shut to the width of a person. Its edges scraped against his shoulder, shaving heat through his coat.

The wall behind them split open.

A black arm slid out to the elbow.

Kai shoved Sora toward the gap. "Go!"

She crawled, caught herself on the soft threshold, and looked back. "Together!"

"I'm right behind you."

The arm in the wall flexed. Its hand found the floor.

Kai pushed himself up. The gap's darkness pressed against his side like a living current. He reached for Sora's hand.

Their fingers touched.

Then the corridor spoke.

Not in Sora's voice this time.

In Kai's.

"Kai."

Sora's hand vanished from his.

The gap widened violently. A force tore between them, cold enough to numb his fingers. Kai grabbed at her sleeve, but the fabric slipped through his grasp. Sora fell forward into the darkness.

"Sora!"

Her face turned toward him. Her mouth formed his name, but no sound came out.

Then the black swallowed her.

Kai lunged after her.

The threshold accepted him to the knee and stopped. He struck something solid beneath the darkness, a wall or a floor standing where neither should have been. His palms hit a surface colder than stone.

"Sora!"

No answer.

The gap remained open around him. Its interior had no depth, yet his hands told him there was a narrow pocket ahead, enclosed on every side. Pure black pressed against his face. He smelled wet metal. Somewhere beyond his reach, something dragged its nails across the unseen surface.

He crawled forward.

His shoulder passed through. His chest followed. The darkness tightened around his ribs.

"Sora," he whispered.

From directly ahead, she answered.

"Kai."

He froze.

The voice was close enough to touch.

His hand moved through the black and found fingers.

They were cold.

He closed around them.

The fingers closed back.

For one breath, relief loosened his throat.

Then he felt the shape of the hand.

Too many joints.

Kai jerked away, but the fingers held him. The gap behind his back began to contract, sealing the corridor out. He twisted, kicked, and felt his heel strike nothing. The black

pocket had no floor beneath his legs now. He hung between spaces, one hand trapped in the grip of whatever had answered.

The voice whispered his name again.

The gap widened around his shoulders.

Kai pulled once more, and the thing pulled back.

Behind him, somewhere beyond the narrowing seam, the alarm clock began ticking beneath its casing.

Ahead, the black pocket opened wider.

Kai stepped toward it and realized there was nowhere to go.

The gap led to a dead-end pocket of pure black.

CHAPTER 15

The Black Pocket Eats Names

Kai stepped into the black and struck something that felt like air turned to stone.

The impact drove him backward. His shoulder hit nothing, yet pain flashed through it. He reached for the gap behind him, found a vertical edge, and dragged his fingers along it. The surface was smooth, colder than the corridor wall, and narrowing beneath his touch.

“Kai?”

Sora’s voice came from somewhere ahead.

He turned toward it. There was no darkness to measure here. Darkness implied distance, corners, a floor. This place had none. Black pressed against his eyes and filled his mouth with the taste of iron. Every breath scraped in as if the air had hardened around him.

“Sora!”

His voice traveled less than an arm’s length before stopping.

He shoved both hands forward. The air resisted. His palms flattened against an invisible wall, yielding only slightly, like skin stretched over a sealed door.

“I’m here,” Sora said.

The sound came from his left.

Kai twisted and struck at it. His knuckles met the same solid pressure. A numb ache climbed into his wrist.

"Where are you?"

"I don't know."

Her answer was close enough to touch and impossibly far away. He could hear the faint strain in her breathing, the tiny catch before each word. That was Sora. The real Sora, or the pocket's idea of her. He had trusted voices before. He had followed one into the corridor. He had opened the wrong gap.

He pressed his forehead against the air.

"I need to get back."

"To what?" Sora asked.

The question slid under his ribs.

"To you. To the corridor."

"Which corridor?"

Kai shut his eyes, though it changed nothing. He pictured the last room: the warped floor, the seam opening beneath it, the thing wearing his face stepping through. He pictured Sora's hand around his wrist. He pictured the door, the clocks, the phone glowing with 8:00 PM.

Then the image tore.

He saw a kitchen instead. A yellow cup beside a sink. Rain trembling against a window. Someone laughing in the next room.

The memory vanished before he could reach it.

Kai sucked in a breath. The pocket tightened around his chest.

"What was that?" Sora asked.

"My house."

"Was it?"

He forced himself to remember the bedroom. The red-numbered digital clock. The green-numbered alarm clock ticking beneath its casing. The phone showing 8:00 PM, its screen holding a reflection that moved after he did.

He whispered each object aloud.

"Clock. Phone. Door. Bed."

The words felt loose. The last one slipped away first. He knew there had been something large in the room, something that breathed and shifted its frame, but the word for it dissolved before he could hold it.

Sora made a small sound.

"Kai, stop naming things."

"I have to. If I don't - "

"You're feeding it."

The air gave a quiet, wet creak.

Kai pulled his hands back. The invisible wall had warmed beneath his palms.

"What does it want?"

"Whatever you use to prove you're here."

He laughed once, without humor. "Then I'll give it something else."

He reached for his phone. His pocket was empty.

The realization came with such force that his knees buckled. He caught himself against the air and felt it flex beneath him. The phone had been in his hand when the gap opened. He remembered its cold case, the pale screen, the reflection of his face staring back with a different posture.

He remembered the battery percentage.

He could not remember what it had been.

"Kai?" Sora said.

"My phone is gone."

"Was it ever with you?"

"Yes."

The answer came too quickly. He heard the doubt inside it.

He searched his clothes. Fabric dragged against his fingers, coarse and damp. His injured side throbbed where the bedframe had scraped him, though he could no longer summon the shape of the thing that had done it. His fingertips found a torn seam in his sleeve. Beneath it, skin. Beneath the skin, bone.

He began naming himself.

"Kai Marlowe."

The pocket shuddered.

The name remained.

"Kai Marlowe," he said again, louder.

Something brushed the back of his neck. Not a hand. A pressure, testing the outline of him.

He stumbled forward. The air released him and then closed around his ankles. He fell onto a surface that was neither floor nor wall. His cheek touched it. It was warm, faintly ridged, and smelled of dust after rain.

Sora's voice came from above him.

"Tell me your name."

"Kai Marlowe."

"Again."

"Kai Marlowe."

The third time, the surname broke apart.

Kai felt the first syllable leave him. Mar - ? No. The shape of it collapsed, leaving only a blank pressure behind his teeth.

He pushed himself upright.

"What did you call me?"

Sora did not answer.

"Sora."

"I'm here."

"What did you call me?"

Silence.

He reached toward her voice. His hand met fingers. They were cold and trembling. He seized them.

"You know my name."

"I know who you are."

"That isn't what I asked."

Her grip tightened around his.

"Kai."

The pocket creaked again.

He flinched. The sound came from everywhere, like a house settling around a buried body.

"Don't say it," he whispered.

"I have to know where you are."

"No. It takes it when you say it."

"Then what am I supposed to call you?"

He had no answer. The question opened a deeper hollow inside him. He tried to think of the name his mother had used. He tried to hear it in a kitchen bright with rainlight. He saw the yellow cup. He saw a hand reaching for it. The face attached to the hand had no features.

His mother's name was gone.

The pocket pressed down.

Kai let go of Sora and crawled backward. His palms slipped over the ridged surface. It rose around him, not moving, but changing its angle whenever he moved, keeping him centered.

"No," he said.

A memory surfaced.

He was younger, standing in a hallway. Someone had called him by his full name. Not Kai. Something longer. A private name. A middle name spoken only when he was sick, frightened, or in trouble.

He caught the first sound.

“Evan.”

The pocket recoiled.

Sora inhaled sharply.

Kai clung to the memory. Evan. It belonged to him. He could feel its edges: a birthday candle, a school form, a voice saying it from a doorway. He said it again.

“Evan.”

The air split with a sound like fabric ripping underwater.

A thin line appeared in front of him. Not light. The absence of black, a narrow seam where the pocket had failed to close. Beyond it, he sensed the corridor’s damp plaster and the faint metallic tick of the green-numbered alarm clock.

Sora’s fingers found his wrist.

“Make it wider.”

“How?”

“Use the mark.”

“What mark?”

“The one you left before.”

He looked at his hands. The skin was pale and blurred at the fingertips. He could not remember leaving any mark. He could not remember what a mark should be.

The seam began to shrink.

Kai pressed his index finger against the air and dragged it downward. Resistance burned through the nail. The line he made was invisible, but the pocket reacted. A groove opened beneath his finger, black within black, its edges shining with a dull gray wetness.

He carved a crooked shape: a vertical stroke, a broken circle, three short cuts crossing the middle.

The moment he finished, the pocket convulsed.

Sora cried out. Her hand tore from his.

Kai lunged and caught her sleeve. The fabric stretched between them. For one instant he saw her - not clearly, but as a pale outline suspended in the black, her face turned away.

"Sora!"

Her name struck the pocket like a stone.

Her outline vanished.

Kai gripped the carved mark with both hands and pulled. The air opened.

Cold rushed through the gap. He smelled plaster, old dust, and the faint burnt scent of the red-numbered digital clock. Something ticked beyond the opening, fast and uneven.

He drove one shoulder through.

The pocket held him at the waist.

Pain crushed his ribs. His feet kicked against nothing. Behind him, the black tightened, swallowing the shape of his legs. He dug his fingers into the edges of the mark. The cuts he had made collapsed beneath his nails.

He thought of Sora's wrist in his hand.

He thought of the corridor.

He thought of the name Evan.

The last thought slipped.

Kai screamed and pulled harder.

The pocket released him.

He spilled onto the corridor floor, striking his chin against the tiles. Sound returned all at once: the alarm clock's frantic ticking, the low electrical hum of the red-numbered clock, his own ragged breathing.

He rolled onto his back.

The gap hung above him, a thin vertical wound in the air. The crooked mark remained carved across it. Beyond the tear, there was only black.

"Sora?"

No answer.

He pushed himself up. The corridor leaned to one side. The wall felt damp and faintly warm beneath his palm, just as it had before the square opened. He looked back at the wound.

He knew someone was missing.

He knew he had held someone's hand.

He knew the name Sora.

But when he tried to remember the name that had opened the pocket, the name that belonged between his first and last, his mind found only a smooth, empty place.

"Kai," he said, testing the sound.

It stayed.

Marlowe came after it, distant but present.

The middle name was gone.

Inside the wound, something scraped once against the other side.

Kai froze.

Then, from the black pocket, Sora whispered a name he no longer possessed.

CHAPTER 16

A Map Made of Ripples

The scrape came again, this time beneath Kai's palm.

He jerked away from the black wound in the corridor wall. The geometric tiles around it had been white when he entered the Transition Void. Now their edges glimmered with a dull blue light, and thin lines moved beneath the surfaces as if something were swimming under glass.

"Kai," Sora whispered from inside the wound.

He knew the voice. He knew the pause before his name, the way she pressed the first syllable low in her throat when she was afraid. But the black pocket had taken something from him. His middle name was gone, cleanly removed from the place where it had lived. He could feel the shape of the absence whenever he tried to remember himself.

"Sora," he said. His voice sounded scraped raw. "Say it again."

"Kai."

The wound tightened around the sound. Its edges drew inward, and a pale ripple crossed the nearest tile.

He stepped back.

The corridor stretched away on both sides, identical geometric walls narrowing into darkness. Behind him, the opening through which he had escaped had sealed without

a seam. Ahead, the floor shone with damp-looking patterns. The tiles were not wet. When he touched one, it shivered beneath his fingers.

Sora's voice came from the wall again.

"Don't follow the straight line."

"What line?"

The ripple spread from beneath his hand. It crossed three tiles, bent sharply, and vanished under the wall. A second ripple rose behind it, then a third. Together they formed a path: not a line, exactly, but a sequence of widening rings that touched at their edges.

Kai looked toward the black wound.

"Where are you?"

There was no answer.

He pressed his palm to the wall. Cold traveled through his fingers. For an instant, he saw Sora on the other side, standing in a corridor that sloped upward. Her face was pale, her hair stuck to one cheek, and one hand was clamped over her mouth. Behind her, something with no face leaned close enough to touch her shoulder.

Then the image folded shut.

Kai struck the wall. "Sora!"

The tiles answered with a dull knock from somewhere far away.

He took out his phone. The screen lit his hand in a weak rectangle. It still displayed 8:00 PM, though the battery percentage had changed again. A reflection of his face stared back from the black glass, delayed by half a second.

He lowered the phone.

The first ripple pulsed.

"Fine," he muttered. "Show me."

He followed the marks.

At once, the corridor altered. The tiles ahead flattened into a clean white path, while the tiles behind him darkened, their patterns turning inward like closing eyes. Kai moved faster. His scraped arm throbbed where the bedframe had caught him, and every step sent a sharp ache through his knee. He kept one hand against the wall, feeling the vibrations pass beneath the geometric shapes.

The map did not remain still.

A ripple appeared beneath his left foot. Kai froze and lifted it. The tile bulged, then settled.

Another path formed to his right, traveling toward a dark angle in the corridor.

"That one?" he called.

Nothing answered.

He crouched and watched the surfaces. The right-hand ripples widened as they moved, but the left-hand path tightened into small, frantic circles. The right path seemed calmer. More deliberate.

He placed his weight on the first tile.

The corridor gave a soft, wet click.

The wall beside him opened an eye.

It was not an eye in flesh. It was a black diamond between the geometric lines, reflecting the corridor from a different angle. In the reflection, Kai stood with his back turned. Sora was beside him, her hand in his.

Then the reflected Sora looked up.

“Wrong,” she said.

Kai spun around.

There was only the empty corridor.

The ripple under his foot collapsed. The tile went dark, and a crack opened across it. Something moved below the floor, scraping along the underside.

He jumped back as fingers pressed up through the crack.

They were pale and jointed incorrectly, the knuckles bending sideways. Kai stumbled into the wall. The geometric patterns flexed beneath his shoulder.

“Which way?” he shouted. “You keep telling me what not to do.”

The fingers withdrew.

Sora’s voice came from the floor now, thin and strained. “It changes when you look at it.”

“What does?”

“The route.”

“Then stop hiding the answer!”

Silence.

The phone in his hand vibrated. Its screen had gone black, but the reflection remained. His reflected face was turned toward the left-hand corridor.

Kai stared at it.

The reflection raised one finger and pointed.

He looked left. A faint ripple moved along the floor, almost invisible. It passed beneath the geometric wall and emerged again several yards away.

He followed it.

The corridor narrowed until his shoulders brushed both sides. The tiles changed beneath his hands. Triangles became concentric squares, then six-sided shapes that seemed to rotate without moving. A low ticking began inside the wall.

The alarm clock.

Kai stopped. The green-numbered clock glowed behind the tiles, its ticking trapped beneath its casing. Each click made the patterns jump.

Sora had warned him about the clocks. The time kept the space stable. The red digital clock had always shown 8:00 PM. The green clock had ticked beneath itself, even when its cord was pulled free.

Now the ticking marked the ripples.

One click. A circle opened ahead.

Another. It closed.

Kai watched three cycles. The route appeared only between the ticks, each time in a different place.

The map was not showing where he could go.

It was testing where he would look.

A whisper slid through the wall. "Kai."

He leaned close. "Sora?"

"Don't make it remember you."

His reflection appeared in the nearest tile. It had no middle name. Neither did he. The thought arrived without words, a hollow pressure behind his eyes.

"What does that mean?"

The reflection's mouth moved before his did.

"Evan."

The name struck him like a blow.

The wall rippled outward. Every tile in the corridor lit at once, and the route burst into view: rings crossing rings, paths branching, folding back, running through the walls and ceiling. At the center of the pattern stood a single dark point.

Sora's voice rose from it.

"Kai, come here."

He took one step.

The dark point shifted.

Not far. Only the width of a tile. But the ripples rearranged around it, and the path that had led toward Sora became a closed loop.

Kai stopped.

"You moved it," he said.

"I didn't."

"You said my name."

"I'm trying to keep you from disappearing."

The voice sounded closer now, but it came from everywhere. From the floor. From the ceiling. From the phone in his hand.

The reflection on the screen lifted its head.

Behind it stood Sora.

Her eyes were closed.

Kai turned the phone over. The glass showed only his own face, pale and exhausted. At the edge of the reflection, something brushed past Sora's shoulder.

He thrust the phone into his pocket.

The ripples began to race.

The corridor shook. Geometric tiles slid over one another with a grinding sound, their corners interlocking. A section of wall folded inward, revealing a narrow opening. Beyond it lay another stretch of corridor, but the floor there was made of black glass.

Sora cried out.

"Kai!"

This time the sound came from the opening.

He ran.

The first tile sank beneath his heel. He lunged forward as the floor softened around his boot. Cold climbed his ankle. Beneath the surface, he saw a red-numbered clock floating upside down.

8:00 PM.

The digits flickered.

Kai pulled free, leaving the heel of his shoe behind. He crossed the next three tiles as they rippled under him. The opening widened, then narrowed. He reached it and threw himself through.

The black-glass corridor vanished.

He landed on hard stone, shoulder first. Pain flashed down his arm. For several seconds he could hear nothing but his own breathing and the faint tick of the alarm clock somewhere behind the walls.

Then Sora spoke.

"You came alone."

Kai rolled onto his back.

She stood at the far end of the passage, half swallowed by darkness. Her outline trembled at the edges, breaking into thin horizontal bands. Each time the bands separated, the wall showed through her.

He pushed himself upright. "I came for you."

"You came because the map let you."

"Are you real?"

Her expression tightened.

"You asked me that before."

"I need an answer."

"You need to move."

The passage behind her was lined with geometric patterns instead of tiles. They were cut directly into the walls, deep grooves filled with a faint silver light. The shapes did not ripple. They rearranged themselves in slow, deliberate turns.

Kai took a step toward her.

Sora lifted her hand. "Wait."

He stopped.

A line in the wall rotated. The silver pattern became a door-shaped outline, then broke apart.

"If you cross before it settles," she said, "it will put you somewhere that has already happened."

"Somewhere you've been?"

"Somewhere I was."

The words landed harder than they should have.

Kai looked at the trembling bands around her body. "You're fading."

"I know."

"How long?"

Sora glanced at the wall. "Until it finishes drawing you."

The silver grooves brightened. Behind her, the geometric shapes formed a map of the corridor, but the route did not lead toward her. It led past her, through the darkness behind her shoulder.

Kai shook his head. "That's not where you are."

"No."

"Then the map is wrong."

"It isn't a map of places."

Another line turned. A shape like a narrow hand appeared in the wall, pointing beyond Sora.

Kai understood before he wanted to.

"It shows what happens if I follow it."

Sora's eyes opened fully. "It shows what the corridor wants to happen."

"And if I refuse?"

The patterns stopped.

For the first time, the passage went completely silent.

Sora looked at him with sudden terror. "Then it has to invent another way."

Behind Kai, something scraped against the stone.

He turned.

The route he had followed was gone. The corridor had sealed behind him, leaving only a smooth geometric wall. In its center, a new pattern began to form.

A face.

His face.

The mouth opened.

"Kai," it said in Sora's voice.

Sora reached for him. Her fingers passed through the darkness between them, becoming transparent at the tips.

"Don't listen," she said.

The false voice spoke again. "Evan."

Kai flinched. The missing name stirred in the black space inside him, not returning, only being touched.

The wall behind Sora began to brighten. The geometric grooves aligned into a tall opening. Beyond it was not darkness but a pale, depthless glow. Wind moved through it, carrying the dry tick of the green clock.

Sora's body flickered.

Kai ran toward her.

The map changed.

Silver lines raced across the walls, redrawing the opening behind her. The passage bent. Sora slid away without moving, dragged backward by the geometry itself.

"Kai!" she shouted.

He caught her wrist.

For one instant she was solid. Her pulse struck against his fingers, fast and uneven.

Then the wall pulled.

Kai braced his feet against the stone. His injured knee buckled. Sora's arm stretched between them, her skin thinning into light.

"Let go," she gasped.

"No."

"It's using me to draw the next route."

"I said no."

The patterns flared.

Pain tore through his hand. The wall showed him a dozen versions of Sora, each one reaching from a different opening. In one, she was crying. In another, she was smiling. In the last, she had no face at all.

Kai closed his eyes and followed the ripples he could feel beneath the stone.

Not the brightest route.

The smallest one.

A tremor passed from Sora's wrist into his palm, then into the floor. The pattern beneath his feet answered with three tight pulses. Kai shifted left, dragging Sora with him.

The wall resisted.

He shifted again.

The geometric grooves snapped into place.

A seam opened beside them.

Kai pulled with everything he had. Sora tore free of the wall and fell against him. Together they crashed through the seam as the false voice screamed his lost name behind them.

They landed in a narrow passage lined entirely with geometric patterns.

No tiles. No clocks. No visible floor breaks.

The walls rose close on either side, their silver shapes turning in silence. Ahead, a dark opening waited beneath an arch of interlocking triangles.

Sora lay against Kai's chest, breathing in shallow bursts. Her edges still trembled, but she had stopped fading.

Kai looked back.

The seam had vanished. In its place, the patterns formed a living route, rippling away from their feet toward the opening ahead.

He got up and helped Sora stand.

"Is that the next transition point?" he asked.

She stared at the arch.

"I don't know."

The ripples moved again, one after another, leading forward.

Behind them, the wall whispered his name.

Ahead, the opening widened.

Kai tightened his grip on Sora's hand and stepped onto the first silver shape.



Geometric Patterns Bite Back

Kai's foot found the silver shape, and the corridor snapped shut around it.

The pattern flashed beneath his shoe. Lines divided, crossed, and folded into one another with the clean precision of a diagram. For half a second, he saw a route through the opening: three pale angles leading toward the dark beyond.

Then the angles opened.

Not like doors. Like mouths.

Kai tore his foot back. The silver lines contracted with a dry clicking sound, and the nearest points sharpened into rows of small, white teeth. They bit the air where his ankle had been. A cold gust struck his leg, carrying the smell of wet stone and something metallic.

Sora stumbled against him.

"Kai - "

"I've got you." He caught her wrist before she slid toward the wall. His scraped palm burned around her skin. "Don't step on the lines."

"I wasn't planning to."

The corridor had no true floor anymore. Silver shapes drifted across it in connected bands, each one changing as they watched. Triangles became diamonds. Diamonds flattened into narrow slits. The walls rippled around the geometric openings, their surfaces flexing as though something beneath them had begun to turn in its sleep.

Kai looked past the first pattern toward the widening opening. The route was still there, but it had shifted. What had been three pale angles now formed a crooked ladder descending into blackness.

"We have to keep moving," he said.

Sora's fingers tightened around his. "You said that before the wall swallowed you."

"And I came back."

"Parts of you came back."

The words struck deeper than the scrape in his hand. For an instant, the black pocket pressed behind his eyes. He remembered the nameless space, the sound against the other side, Sora whispering a name he no longer possessed. He remembered reaching for her and finding only darkness.

He pulled her closer. "Then stay close enough to count."

The first silver shape shuddered.

Kai moved.

He placed his foot between two intersecting lines, where the floor looked dull and harmless. The corridor answered with a low vibration. The lines beside him lifted from the surface, thin as wire, and curled inward. Their ends split into teeth.

He froze.

The teeth snapped together inches from his boot.

Sora made a small sound behind him. "Kai."

"I know."

The pattern spread beneath them. New angles appeared under Sora's shoes, brightening one after another. Each line was too straight to be natural, yet they bent

toward her with unmistakable purpose.

Kai reached back and pulled her over the narrow strip of dark floor behind him. The silver shapes followed. Their edges scraped across the corridor with a sound like fingernails dragged over glass.

"Don't look down," he said.

"That's difficult when the floor is trying to eat us."

"Look at me, then."

She did. Her face had gone pale in the shifting light. The red numbers of the digital clock flickered somewhere behind the warped walls, throwing fragments of 8:00 PM across the corridor. Farther off, beneath the casing of the alarm clock, the green ticking began again - faint, steady, impossibly close.

Kai searched the pattern for the route he had seen in the ripple-map. The silver shapes had once behaved like a trail. He had trusted them because they carried the same cold shimmer as the ripples that had led him out of the black pocket.

Now the trail was watching him.

A diamond opened beside his hand.

He jerked away, but not before his fingertips brushed its edge.

The shape split.

Four pointed forms rose from the wall around his fingers. They were small, translucent, and wet-looking, each one ridged like a tooth. They closed with a sharp clack.

Kai slammed his shoulder into the wall and wrenched free. A point tore through his sleeve and scored the skin beneath. Heat ran down his arm.

Sora grabbed his jacket. "You touched it."

"I know what I did."

"And it reacted."

"I know that too."

The pattern pulsed. More teeth emerged along the wall, spreading toward them in a widening row. The corridor seemed to inhale. The geometric opening ahead narrowed, its black interior pinched between two silver jaws.

Kai forced himself to breathe through the copper taste in his mouth. The patterns were not random. They were responding to contact, pressure, movement. The more he fought them, the faster they formed.

He looked at Sora's hand in his.

A thin silver line had appeared around her wrist.

It was not painted on her skin. It passed through it.

"Sora," he said.

She followed his gaze. "What is that?"

The line tightened.

Her arm jerked toward the wall.

Kai caught her around the waist before she could fall. Something pulled from inside the pattern, hard enough to drag both of them sideways. Sora's shoulder struck his chest. Her breath burst out.

"Kai, let go!"

"I'm not letting go."

The silver line brightened. It ran from her wrist into the nearest diamond, vanishing beneath its surface. The shape flexed around it. Teeth pushed through the wall, each one angled toward her arm.

Sora dug her heels into the floor. "It's attached to me."

"I can see that."

"Cut it."

"With what?"

She looked at him. "Your phone."

His phone was still in his pocket, its screen fixed at 8:00 PM despite the absence of any signal. He pulled it free. The glass reflected his face, but the reflection was turned slightly away, watching something behind him.

Kai ignored it. He gripped the phone by its edges and brought it down on the silver tether.

The impact rang through the corridor.

The line did not break. Instead, the phone screen filled with white geometric cracks. In the reflection, his other self smiled.

The tether yanked.

Sora screamed as her feet left the floor.

Kai locked both arms around her waist. His injured hand slipped against her coat, slick with blood. The pattern dragged them toward the wall, inch by inch. The teeth along its surface opened and closed, opening wider each time.

"Kai!" Sora clawed at his sleeve. "It's pulling me in!"

"I know!"

The corridor tilted. He hit one knee. Silver shapes slid beneath him, arranging themselves into a long, narrow mouth. The teeth rose around his leg, scraping his jeans.

He had followed the route because it had led him to Sora. He had trusted the shapes because he needed something that behaved like a map.

But maps did not choose what they carried.

Kai shoved the phone between Sora's wrist and the tether. The cracked screen pressed against the silver line. The reflection on it twisted, its mouth widening without sound.

"Say my name," Sora gasped.

"What?"

"Say it."

The tether pulled again. Her wrist bent toward the wall at an angle no joint should take.

"Kai," she said, and the corridor answered with a deep metallic groan.

He understood then. The patterns had reacted when he touched them. The corridor had opened when Sora said his name. It had listened before. It was listening now.

He tightened his grip and shouted, "Sora!"

The name struck the air.

Every silver shape stopped.

The teeth held open.

For one suspended moment, the corridor became perfectly still. The red digits flickered on the wall. The green ticking ceased beneath its casing. Even the cold

seemed to pause against Kai's face.

Then the pattern turned.

Not toward Sora.

Toward him.

The tether around her wrist loosened by a fraction. Kai seized the change. He twisted, planted his boots against the dull strip of floor, and hauled Sora backward with everything left in his shoulders.

The silver line snapped against the phone.

A sound came from inside the wall - a wet, furious click.

Sora struck the floor beside him. Kai fell with her, shielding her as the geometric teeth slammed shut where her head had been. The impact shook dust from the ceiling. A strip of silver tore free and whipped across the corridor, striking the opposite wall hard enough to leave a glowing scar.

For several seconds, neither of them moved.

Then Sora shoved at his chest. "Get off me."

Kai rolled away and tried to stand. His knee buckled. The corridor swayed around him, its angles sliding out of alignment. The opening ahead had widened again, but the path toward it was no longer a ladder.

It was a row of narrow, silver triangles.

Each triangle pointed forward.

Each one had teeth.

Sora sat up, clutching her wrist. The silver line remained, faint but visible, circling her skin like a wire beneath glass.

Kai reached for her. "Can you walk?"

She looked at the opening. "Ask me after we're somewhere that doesn't have a mouth."

The digital clock flashed again behind the wall.

8:00 PM.

Its red light spilled across Sora's face. Her wrist jerked.

Not toward the nearest pattern this time.

Toward the opening.

Kai caught her arm and pulled her against him. The tether went taut between her skin and the dark beyond the geometric shapes.

Something on the other side pulled once.

Gently.

As if testing its grip.

Sora's eyes met his. "Kai."

He wrapped his injured hand around her wrist, ignoring the pain, and dragged her away from the opening.

Her arm jerked after it.

Not like a stumble. Not like a reflex.

Like an unseen tether had caught hold of her and refused to let go.

The Tether Breaks Into Two

“Don’t pull me,” Sora said. “It wants the movement.”

Kai’s hand was locked around her wrist, and the corridor wall pressed warm and damp against his shoulder. Behind them, the activated square opened another inch. Its edges shone with the same silver geometry that had bitten into the floor, folding and unfolding like teeth.

“I’m not pulling you,” Kai said.

The tether jerked.

Sora lurched forward. Her fingers tore against his grip, and the sound that came from her throat was small, almost swallowed by the ticking beneath the alarm clock casing somewhere behind the walls.

Kai dug his heels into the corridor. The plaster softened under his back. Something moved inside it, sliding parallel to his spine.

“Then what are you doing?”

“Keeping you here.”

The words barely left him before the tether tightened again.

It was not visible in the ordinary sense. Kai saw it only when he stopped looking directly at it: a narrow distortion stretching from Sora’s ribs into the black opening ahead. The air bent around it. Silver angles flashed along its length, each one cutting a thin line of light across Sora’s coat.

The corridor had narrowed since he had followed her voice. The wall on one side leaned inward. The other side had become a depthless drop, though Kai could still feel its rough plaster beneath his fingertips. Somewhere beyond the threshold, something exhaled with the wet patience of a sleeping animal.

Sora twisted toward him. Her face was pale, but her eyes held steady.

"Kai, let go."

"No."

"The tether is using you as an anchor."

"Then I'll be the anchor."

"You don't know what that means."

"I know what happens if I let go."

Another pull dragged her half a step forward. Her boot scraped the floor. The geometric pattern beneath it flared white, and pain snapped through Kai's wrist as if the line had passed through his bones.

He saw the black pocket for an instant - the place that had resisted every movement and eaten pieces of his name. He saw the silver shapes waiting beneath his palm. He heard Sora whispering a name he no longer possessed.

Then the image broke.

Sora struck the wall with her free hand. "It's splitting."

Kai looked down.

The distortion between them had changed. A second line had formed beside the first, thinner and darker, running from the center of Sora's chest back toward him. The original tether pulled forward into the unstable space. The new one angled down, disappearing beneath Kai's feet.

His stomach turned cold.

"No," he said.

The floor answered with a crack.

Kai's left leg sank to the ankle. Not through the surface - into it. The corridor swallowed his boot and closed around his shin with a pressure like clenched fingers. He dropped against the wall, still holding Sora.

She reached for his shoulder. "Kai."

"I have you."

"You have both of us."

The second tether tightened.

The pull on Sora became violent. Her body snapped forward, and Kai's shoulder wrenched so hard that his vision flashed white. At the same time, the floor dragged him downward. His fingers slipped across her wrist.

Sora caught his hand.

For one breath they were joined at the threshold, her body angled toward the opening, his half-submerged in the corridor floor. The space beyond them flickered through impossible versions of itself: a hallway with the digital clock glowing red at 8:00 PM, a narrow passage filled with green light, a room where the bedframe breathed beneath a hanging moth.

The alarm clock ticked beneath its casing.

Tick.

Tick.

Tick.

The tether pulled on every sound.

"Kai," Sora said. "Look at me."

He did.

Her face kept changing at the edges. Not into another face. Into absence. The skin around her cheek blurred, then returned. Her eyes remained hers.

"We can't keep doing this," she said.

"I can cut it."

"With what?"

Kai glanced toward the opening. Along its edge, the geometry had sharpened into a row of silver planes. They were not objects. They were seams in the air, thin enough to pass a finger through and bright enough to show him the blood on his knuckles.

The pattern had bitten him before.

This time, he needed it to bite the tether.

Sora followed his gaze. "No."

"It's the only thing here with an edge."

"It won't know the difference between the line and us."

"Then I'll make it."

The floor sank another inch around his leg. Cold traveled up through his bones. Beneath the surface, something tugged at his ankle with careful, testing movements.

Sora's grip tightened. "Kai, if you cut the wrong thread - "

"I won't."

"You don't know which one is mine."

He looked again.

The two tethers crossed between them. One shivered toward Sora's chest and continued forward. The other ran through Kai's hand, down into the floor, and vanished beneath the threshold. They were joined at a point just below Sora's ribs, braided so tightly that his eyes could not separate them.

But the reflection in the opening showed something else.

In the black surface, Sora stood upright and still. Kai's reflected body was bent beneath her, one hand around hers. Between them hung a single pale cord.

Then the reflection moved late.

The pale cord split.

One half pulled Sora into the darkness. The other half pulled Kai down.

Kai understood. Not because the space explained itself, but because Sora's reflected mouth formed words before the real one did.

"Cut the one that goes down."

Sora's real voice came a moment later. "Cut the one that goes down."

Kai's breath shook. "How do you know?"

"I don't."

The opening widened behind her. A draft came through, carrying the smell of wet dust and overheated wires. Sora's hair lifted toward it.

"Kai," she said, "do it now."

He released her wrist.

The sudden loss of resistance threw Sora forward. She cried out and caught the edge of the threshold with both hands. Kai's arm plunged into the floor to the elbow. The dark material closed around him, hot and slick.

The tethers stretched between them.

He reached toward the silver seam.

It was farther than it looked. His shoulder ground against the floor. The geometry shifted beneath his palm, rearranging itself into angles that made his teeth ache. He pressed his fingers into the brightest edge.

Pain opened his hand.

The seam bit through skin and muscle. Warm blood ran across the silver surface, and the pattern lit from within.

The tether jerked.

Sora's body slammed against the threshold. Her fingers scraped, leaving red marks that vanished as soon as they appeared.

"Kai!"

"I'm here."

"No, you're underneath me."

His arm was disappearing into the floor. He could feel the thing below his ankle climbing higher, wrapping his calf, his knee. The downward tether had become a cord of pressure inside him.

He dragged the glowing seam toward it.

The corridor screamed.

Not a sound from the walls. A sound made by distance itself, by the space between one place and another being forced open. The digital clock flashed in the opening. 8:00 PM became 8:00, then a row of red bars, then Kai's own reflection staring back at him with a colder light.

The reflected Kai stood differently.

Straighter.

Unhurt.

He raised one hand and pointed toward the lower tether.

Kai drove the silver edge down.

The cut did not pass through the cord. It caught.

For an instant, the tether resisted. The force traveled through Kai's arm and into his shoulder. His joints pulled apart. His mouth filled with the taste of metal.

Sora screamed his name.

The line split under the seam.

The downward half snapped first.

Kai fell.

His body dropped through the corridor floor, but his hand remained locked around the silver edge. The threshold tore open beneath him, revealing a depth packed with fragments: the black pocket, the bedroom, the underside of the bedframe, the green-numbered alarm clock glowing in the dark. All of them rotated below like pieces of a house sinking through deep water.

The second tether tightened around Sora.

She was pulled forward.

"Kai!"

He swung beneath the threshold, one arm holding him to the cut, the other reaching for her. His fingertips brushed hers.

He caught two fingers.

The force dragging her away increased. Her nails bent against his skin. The opening beyond her had no floor, no ceiling, no direction. It only continued.

"I can pull you back," he said.

Sora's face twisted. "No."

"I can."

"If you do, it takes you too."

He saw it then. The remaining tether had not vanished when he cut the lower branch. It had become clean, bright, almost deliberate. It ran from Sora into the next space, while the severed end burned between them.

The tether no longer bound them together.

It only remembered that they had been.

Sora looked at his hand around hers. "You cut it."

"I cut yours."

"You cut the one that was killing you."

"Same thing."

A tremor passed through the threshold. The silver geometry began to close. Each plane folded inward, crushing the space between them.

Kai tried to pull himself up. The floor offered no grip. His injured hand slid along the edge, leaving a dark smear.

Sora leaned toward him, but the forward tether dragged her farther. Her fingers began to slip from his.

"Kai, listen."

"No."

"Listen."

The edge cut deeper into his palm.

Sora's expression softened - not with surrender, but with the terrible calm she wore when she had already chosen something.

"The next space is not the room," she said. "Don't follow the clocks."

"What does that mean?"

"The time is still wrong."

Her fingers slipped.

Kai caught her wrist again.

The threshold buckled. The corridor wall folded over itself, and for a moment Sora appeared in three places: above him, beside him, and far ahead beneath a red 8:00 PM glowing in the dark.

Only one of her wrists was real.

Kai chose the one that hurt.

His grip closed.

The tether answered by tearing the distance between them wider.

Sora's wrist slid from his hand.

Her last touch was the scrape of her fingernails across his knuckles. Then she was pulled through the opening, forward into the unstable space. The bright tether followed her like a thread drawn through cloth.

Kai dropped another foot.

The silver seam began to close around his forearm. He hooked his elbow over the threshold and hauled himself upward with a cry that broke into a raw, breathless sound. The severed lower tether writhed beneath him, no longer attached to Sora, but still attached to the place that had taken him.

He pulled.

The corridor released his leg.

Kai slammed onto the boundary, half his body on the corridor side, half suspended over the dark. The opening snapped shut behind Sora with a flat, final sound.

Silence followed.

Then the alarm clock ticked beneath its casing.

Kai lay with his cheek against the cold threshold. His hand shook. Blood gathered beneath his palm and slipped into the seam, where the geometry drank it in small, bright pulses.

Beyond the sealed opening, something moved.

Not Sora.

Not yet.

A line appeared in the darkness ahead, thin as a cut made by a blade. It stretched away from the boundary, carrying the faint reflection of her face. The line did not lead back to him. It led onward.

Kai pushed himself to his knees.

The corridor behind him had gone black. The unstable space ahead waited without a floor. Between them, he remained suspended at the boundary, one leg numb, one hand bleeding, and the severed tether curling at his feet like a dead thing that had not learned it was dead.

He reached toward the line carrying Sora's reflection.

The digital clock beyond it changed.

8:00 PM vanished.

A new red number appeared, counting upward.



Sora Falls Through the Wrong Sky

The red number climbed to 8:01, and Kai understood that the clock was not measuring time. It was measuring distance.

He hung beneath the threshold with one hand locked around the silver edge. The cut tether had vanished from his palm, leaving a black line that twitched whenever the geometry folded. Above him, Sora stood on the far side of the opening, her body pulled toward a sky that had no right to exist.

“Kai!”

Her voice came from everywhere at once. From the corridor wall. From the wet darkness below him. From the phone in his pocket, though he had not touched it.

He looked up.

The space beyond the threshold had opened into a vast, colorless sky. Clouds moved beneath Sora’s feet. A red moon hung sideways on the horizon, its surface divided into squares like a broken screen. Sora was falling upward through it, hair streaming toward the ground that wasn’t there.

Kai tightened his grip until the silver edge cut into his fingers.

“Sora, reach for me!”

She twisted, arms flailing. The remaining tether ran from her back into the sky, thin as a strand of wet thread. It pulled her higher with every breath.

“I can’t!”

The digital clock beyond her flashed 8:02.

The threshold narrowed.

Kai's shoulder screamed. His injured side scraped against the underside of the opening, and something cold brushed the back of his neck. He did not look down. Looking down had become an invitation in this place.

He needed to get above the edge. He needed to reach Sora before the void sealed.

That was the simple part.

The harder question had already found him.

If he followed her, would he be rescuing Sora - or offering the pocket another body to fasten into its machinery?

The silver geometry flexed under his hand. His fingers slipped a fraction.

"Kai!" Sora shouted. "Don't let it take you!"

"I'm not letting it take you!"

"You don't know where this goes!"

"I know where you're going!"

Her face appeared sharply for one instant, close enough for him to see the bloodless color of her lips. Then the sky stretched between them. Her features blurred, divided into panes, and each pane showed a different expression: terror, anger, pleading.

The tether jerked.

Sora vanished into the clouds.

Kai hauled himself upward.

His elbow struck the threshold. Pain burst through his arm. He dragged his chest over the silver rim and collapsed beside the opening as it shrank to the width of a hand. The air smelled of rain and hot metal. Beneath him, there was no floor, only a dark surface that reflected him standing upright.

The reflection smiled.

Kai kicked at it.

The silver opening snapped shut.

For a second, there was only the red clock, floating in the impossible sky.

8:03.

Then Sora's hand punched through the clouds.

"Kai!"

He lunged.

His fingers caught hers.

Her skin was freezing. Not cold from weather, but cold like something stored beneath a house for years. Her grip closed around his wrist with desperate strength.

"I found you," he said.

"No." Her eyes widened. "You found the wrong - "

The sky cracked.

A sound like a thousand alarm clocks ticking beneath their casings rolled across the pocket. The clouds folded inward. The red moon split down the middle, revealing a hallway behind it, narrow and wet, lined with doors that opened and closed without hinges.

Sora's hand began to slide from his.

Kai clamped down.

The tether surfaced between them, no longer thin. It had thickened into a pale cord, pulsing with a slow green light. It wrapped once around Sora's waist, then tightened.

"Kai, let go!"

"No."

"It's using me to pull you in!"

"I can pull you both out."

"You cut it once!"

"I can do it again."

He reached for the black line in his palm. The mark burned. The cord reacted immediately, swelling beneath Sora's skin.

She cried out.

Kai stopped.

The question came back, clean and merciless. Rescue or invitation. His hand, his blood, his name - everything he brought near the tether became part of its design. He had already severed one half and fallen through the corridor floor. He had already watched the geometry fold around Sora. If he cut again, he might free her.

Or he might make himself the thing that held her place.

Sora stared at him. Behind her, the nightmare sky opened wider.

"Anchor yourself," she said.

"What?"

"Don't follow me."

"I'm not leaving you."

"That's not what I said." Her fingers tightened around his. "If you come through like this, it will decide what you are."

The red clock flickered.

8:04.

Kai looked at the hallway inside the broken moon. One door stood open at its far end. Green light spilled across the wet floor. Beneath that light, he saw the alarm clock - the green-numbered one, glowing and ticking under its casing.

The pocket had brought him a sound.

A purr followed it.

Soft. Familiar. The cat's purr, impossibly distant, vibrating through the hallway.

Sora heard it too. Her face changed.

"Kai," she whispered. "That isn't coming from there."

The cord yanked her upward.

He made his choice before fear could finish naming it.

Kai wrapped his free hand around the tether.

The cord burned through his palm. Green light flooded his arm, tracing his veins. His body lurched toward Sora, and the sky opened beneath him. He could feel the pocket searching him, testing the shape of his memories, finding the places where his name had already gone thin.

Kai Marlowe.

The words formed inside his skull.

Then the last name stuttered.

Marlowe.

Mar - He bit his tongue until blood filled his mouth.

"Sora!" he shouted.

She reached for him as the clouds swallowed her legs.

"Say it!"

"Kai!"

"No. Say my name!"

"Kai Marlowe!"

The tether pulled harder.

He repeated it, louder, forcing every syllable through the tearing sky.

"Kai Marlowe!"

The hallway doors slammed in sequence. The sound traveled toward them, each impact closer than the last.

Sora's hand slipped.

Kai threw himself after her.

The silver threshold disappeared above him. The red clock fell past his shoulder, its numbers spinning backward now. The nightmare sky became a vertical tunnel of cloud, glass, and black water. Sora dropped ahead of him, reaching back. He saw her face one last time before a sheet of darkness folded between them.

He hit something hard.

For several seconds, he could not breathe. A bitter taste coated his teeth. His cheek rested against a floor that pulsed faintly beneath the skin, as if the room were breathing around him.

Kai pushed himself up.

There was no sky.

He lay in a pocket no larger than a bedroom, though the walls leaned away at impossible angles. A single window occupied the far wall. Beyond it, the same red moon hung over a landscape of upside-down houses. Their roofs pointed into the earth. Their windows glowed with the pale reflection of faces.

Sora was gone.

Kai scrambled to his feet.

“Sora!”

His voice struck the walls and returned in a stranger’s tone.

Sora.

The room answered with a whisper.

Kai.

He turned toward the sound. Nothing moved. A digital clock sat on a low table beneath the window, its red numbers fixed at 8:00 PM. Beside it, the phone lay faceup. Its screen showed 8:00 PM too, with a battery percentage that changed every time he blinked.

The reflection in the phone was not his.

It showed him standing in the nightmare sky, one hand extended toward Sora.

Kai snatched the phone up. The glass was warm.

A purr trembled through the room.

He froze.

It came from somewhere beneath the floorboards. Faint, steady, alive.

"Sora?" he called.

The purr continued.

He dropped to his knees and pressed his ear to the floor. The vibration traveled through his cheek and into his teeth. For one breath, he heard Sora crying somewhere far away.

Then the sound changed.

The purr receded, dragged down a long corridor that did not exist inside the room.

Kai lifted his head.

The window had vanished. In its place stood a door with a dark, reflective surface. His reflection faced him from the other side.

It was holding Sora's hand.

Kai reached for the handle.

The reflection did not move.

Behind it, the purr faded until only the ticking remained - green, patient, and waiting beneath its casing.

CHAPTER 20

The Breaking Becomes a Choice

The ticking stopped.

Kai stood before the unmoving reflection, one hand braced against the wall that had become glass, plaster, and something colder beneath both. The green numbers of the alarm clock glowed behind him, though the clock itself was nowhere in the room. His scraped palm left no mark on the surface. Even the blood had learned to vanish.

Then the reflection blinked.

Kai did not.

A blue line appeared across the reflection's chest. It was thin as a thread and bright enough to hurt. Light leaked through it - not white, not electric, but the dim blue of evening after the sun had dropped behind the houses.

"Sora?" Kai said.

The reflection opened its mouth.

No sound came out. The blue line widened, and the nightmare pocket shuddered around him. The floor tilted. Somewhere below, the red digital clock began counting upward again, each number arriving with a wet click.

Kai caught himself against the wall.

He needed the seam open. That was all. Not escape. Not yet. Sora was somewhere beyond the wrong sky, beyond the corridor that had split beneath his feet. If the blue

light was a path, he had to hold it long enough for her to find him.

The reflection raised one hand and pressed its palm to the other side of the glass.

Kai pressed back.

The surface was warm.

A voice whispered from inside it. "Let go."

Kai's shoulder tightened. "No."

"You already did."

The reflection's face shifted. For an instant it wore Sora's expression, pale and furious. Then it wore Kai's face again, but older, the eyes washed clean of everything he knew.

The pocket buckled.

The walls folded inward like wet cardboard. The air smelled of dust, hot metal, and the faint sweetness of something rotting behind a closed door. Kai shoved harder against the reflection. The blue seam narrowed beneath his palm.

"Sora!" he shouted.

A reply came from the wall behind him.

"Kai!"

He spun. The room had no wall now. It opened onto a long black corridor, its surface rippling as though something enormous moved beneath it. At the far end, Sora stood in a wash of gray light. Her hair clung to her cheek. One hand was wrapped around the remaining tether, which stretched from her wrist into the darkness behind Kai.

"Kai, don't listen to it," she called.

The reflection smiled.

"Which one of us is it?" it asked.

Kai looked from Sora to the glass. The corridor bent between them. Sora's outline doubled, then tripled. One version stood with her hand raised. Another crouched beside the wall. A third faced away, staring into a doorway that was not there.

The tether jerked.

Sora stumbled.

Kai lunged toward her, but the floor split under his boots. Blackness opened in a narrow crack, and the blue seam flared in the reflection, as if his movement had fed it. The pocket was not collapsing randomly. It was waiting for him to choose where the break belonged.

"Hold on!" Kai shouted.

"I am holding on!"

The tether pulled taut between them. It looked thinner than before, nearly transparent, but every vibration traveled through Kai's bones. He could feel Sora's fear in it. Her breath. The sharp, uneven rhythm of her fingers tightening around the cord.

Behind her, the corridor began to close.

Kai searched the room for something solid. The phone lay on the floor near his foot, its screen glowing 8:00 PM. The battery percentage flickered between numbers too quickly to read. In the black screen, his reflection turned its head toward him.

A phrase surfaced in his mind.

The room and the time keep the space stable.

Sora had said it before the window opened inward. Before the moth. Before the silver geometry bit into his foot and the tether divided them.

The clocks had been anchors. His name had been an anchor. Memory, too.

The thought arrived with such certainty that Kai nearly missed the second voice beneath it.

A memory is only an anchor if it is remembered clearly.

The reflection lifted its fingers. Five pale marks appeared in the glass.

Kai's phone buzzed.

The screen changed. Instead of the time, it showed a name.

He stared at it.

The neighbor.

The old man who lived two doors down. The one who had left milk outside his door during the winter power outage. The one whose porch light stayed on all night. Kai could see the cracked blue mug in the man's hand, the wool cardigan, the narrow strip of garden between the houses.

But the name would not come.

He had known it. He had spoken it. He had written it once on an envelope.

The reflection tapped the glass.

"What will you give it?"

Kai's throat went dry. "Nothing."

The corridor behind Sora narrowed to a slit.

She looked over her shoulder. "Kai, the light. Use the light."

"I'm trying."

"No. You're holding it shut."

The words struck harder than the voice in the glass. Kai looked at his hand. The blue seam ran beneath his palm, trembling. It did not need force. It needed a gap.

The reflection leaned close enough that its breath fogged the inside of the surface.

"Give it a truth," it whispered. "Not a thing you invented. Not a thing you can afford to lose."

Kai's grip faltered.

The memory of the neighbor rose before him with unbearable clarity. Rain ticking on the awning. The smell of wet pavement. The neighbor laughing when Kai had apologized for the milk.

A name waited at the edge of the memory.

Kai reached for it.

The pocket screamed.

The sound came from every object at once: the phone vibrating against the floor, the unseen alarm clock ticking beneath its casing, the red numbers changing somewhere below, the walls splitting along invisible seams. Sora cried out as the tether burned bright between them.

"Kai!" she yelled. "Choose!"

He could not remember the name.

That was the horror of it. The sacrifice had already begun. The void had found the loose thread and was pulling.

Kai slammed his bleeding palm against the blue line.

"I give you his name," he said.

The reflection stopped smiling.

The memory bucked inside him. For one second, the name returned - not as a word, but as the shape of a voice calling from across a snow-covered street.

Then it tore away.

Kai gasped. The porch vanished. The blue mug vanished. The cardigan, the garden, the light burning through the neighbor's window - all of it remained, but the person at the center had become nameless.

The void took the name and folded it into the glass.

The seam opened.

Blue hour poured through the crack, cold and soft, carrying the smell of rain and distant trees. It cut across the nightmare pocket in a narrow vertical wound. Beyond it was not another room. It was a strip of ordinary evening sky, deepening above rooftops.

Sora's tether snapped straight.

She stepped toward the opening.

The corridor tried to pull her back. Its walls rippled around her ankles, shaping themselves into hands without fingers. Sora dug in, teeth clenched, and wrapped the tether around her wrist.

Kai reached through the seam.

Their fingers touched.

The contact was real. Warm skin. A trembling pulse.

Sora seized his hand. "Don't let go."

"I won't."

The reflection struck the glass.

Once.

The blue light flickered.

Twice.

The room folded another inch.

Kai dragged Sora toward him. Her shoulder crossed the seam, then her chest. The darkness behind her opened wide, revealing the blank-faced shape standing where the corridor ended. It did not pursue. It only watched, its head tilted as if listening to the name the void had swallowed.

Sora's other hand caught the edge of the opening.

"Kai," she said, breathless. "It's not a door."

"What is it?"

"A choice."

The reflection struck a third time.

The glass shattered without breaking. Every fragment remained suspended in the air, each one showing a different Kai: frightened, furious, empty, smiling. The blue seam narrowed around Sora's waist.

Kai pulled.

Something pulled back.

Pain ripped through his shoulder. The tether cut into Sora's wrist. The corridor filled with the smell of scorched dust.

"Kai, let me go!"

"No."

"If it closes with me in it, it takes you too!"

He saw the truth in her face. Not the reflection's truth. Hers. The same hard fear she had carried when she warned him about the pale squares, when she had called his name and dragged him away from the dark gap.

Kai tightened his grip.

The seam shrank.

He could feel the lost name moving through the pocket like a new law. The void had accepted the trade, but acceptance was not mercy. It had stabilized one opening. It would not keep it open for them.

Kai hooked his fingers around the blue edge.

The light cut into his skin, cold enough to numb him. He pulled Sora through with a final wrench.

They fell together onto a floor of rough wood.

For several seconds, neither moved.

Rain tapped somewhere nearby. Real rain, uneven and dull. The air smelled of wet earth and old paint. Kai rolled onto his back, staring at a ceiling crossed by familiar water stains.

Sora lay beside him, breathing hard.

Behind them, the blue seam remained in the wall.

It was no wider than a knife cut.

Through it, the nightmare pocket trembled. The reflection stood on the other side, still wearing Kai's face. The green clock glowed behind its shoulder. The red digital

numbers climbed in the darkness below.

Sora pushed herself upright and touched the cut on her wrist. "You opened it."

Kai looked at his palm. The blood had returned, thin and bright along the lines of his hand.

"I traded something."

"What?"

He tried to answer.

The neighbor's porch appeared in his mind. The blue mug. The rain. A voice that had once called him by name.

He could not remember what the name was.

Kai turned toward the wall. "Someone's name."

Sora studied him. "Whose?"

He opened his mouth, and the silence that came out felt like a missing tooth.

"I don't know."

The blue seam pulsed.

On its far side, the reflection lifted a hand. Not waving. Pointing.

Beyond it, deeper in the pocket, another line of blue light appeared.

Then another.

A path was forming through the dark - not wide, not safe, but connected.

Sora saw it too. Her expression changed from relief to dread.

"That wasn't there before," she said.

Kai rose unsteadily. His shoulder ached where the tether had pulled him apart. He reached for Sora's hand.

The seam held.

For now.

"What does it lead to?" she asked.

Kai looked through the thin opening at the blue hour spreading across impossible rooftops.

"Somewhere it can still break."

Sora's fingers closed around his.

Together they stood before the narrow light, no longer separated, while the nightmare pocket shifted beyond the wall and made room for a path neither of them had chosen yet.

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The Breaking

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